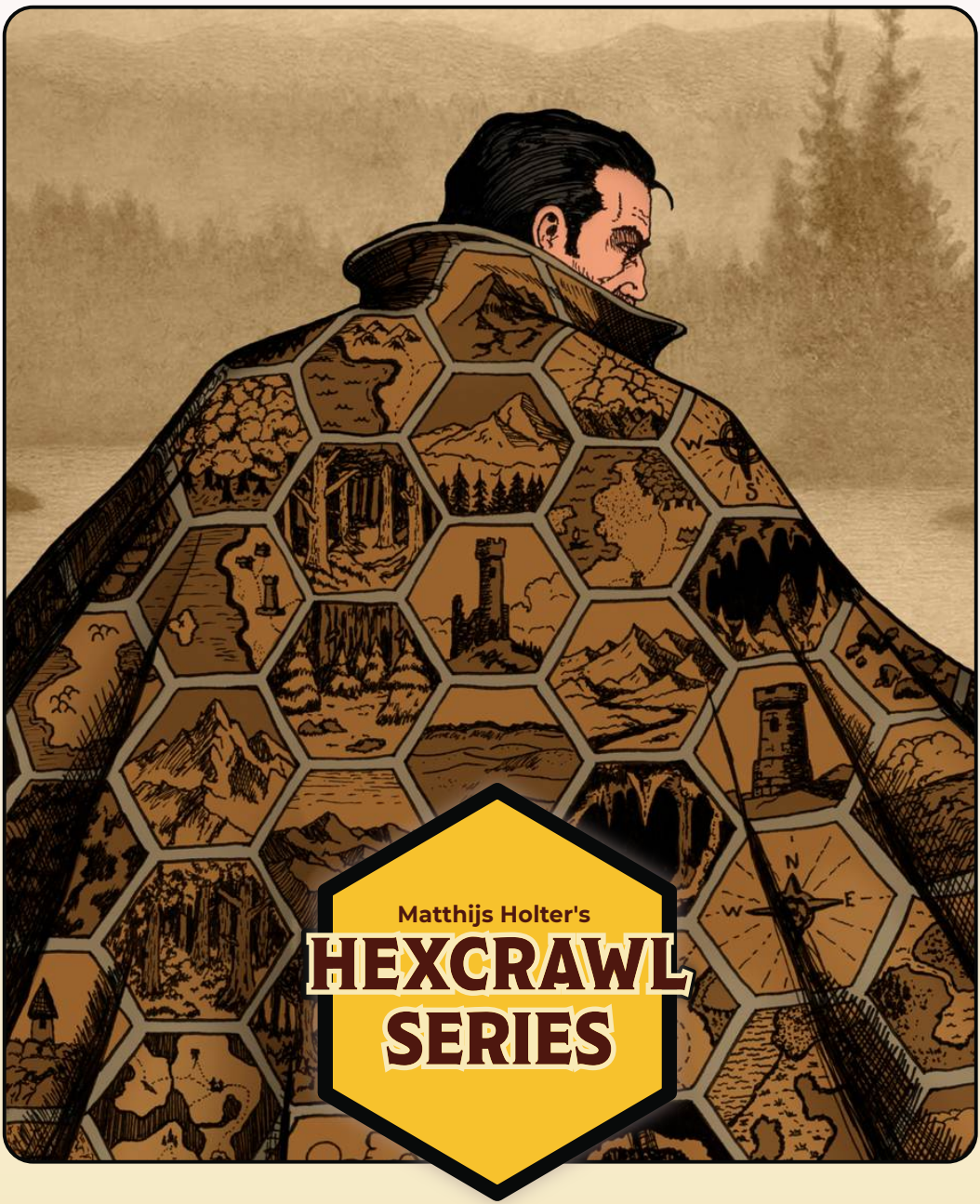
KR1 Publishing presents

THE THORNWALL FRONTIER

A HEXCRAWL ADVENTURE



Matthijs Holter's

HEXCRAWL

The Thornwall Frontier

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How to use this book

You've read the Guidebook. You know how a hexcrawl works: exploration turns, hex keys, forward pointers, radiating prep. Now you need a region to run.

This is that region.

The Thornwall Frontier is a 30-hex starting area built around the same mud-brick town from the Guidebook's worked example in chapter 6. Those 7 hexes are still here, expanded and connected to 23 more. The whole thing is designed so you can read it in an evening and run it Friday. I ran an early version of this region with four hours of prep, and the first session ran five hours.

What's inside:

- *A home base with non-player characters (NPCs), shops, and a rumor board*
- *Three factions pulling the frontier in different directions*
- *30 keyed hexes across three zones: settled, frontier, and deep*
- *Two one-page dungeons ready to drop into a session*
- *Encounter tables, weather, and a Game Master (GM) reference sheet*

How to read it: Front to back the first time. For session prep, read the hexes your players are likely to enter (start with the Settled Ring) and glance at the encounter tables. Keep the GM Reference Sheet open during play.

No stat blocks. Threats are described with plain language: *"a threat a cautious party can handle," "dangerous enough to make retreat smart," "overwhelming."* Use whatever system you're running.

- Matthijs

Table of contents

Your First Session - Pg. 04
An introduction to the hexcrawl

Thornwall - Pg. 09
The home base

Factions - Pg. 18
The factions of Thornwall

Encounter Tables - Pg. 22
Encounter tables by terrain

Rumors - Pg. 30
Rumors to pick up in town or elsewhere

Quest Lines - Pg. 31
A few quest lines to get you going

The Settled Ring - Pg. 33
Hexes 01-10

The Frontier - Pg. 39
Hexes 11-22

The Deep - Pg. 46
Hexes 23-30

The Iron Tower - Pg. 53
A dungeon set in a crumbling tower

The Bone Cult Excavation - Pg. 56
A dungeon set in excavated tunnels underground

Weather and Seasons - Pg. 59
Weather and season tables

NPC Roster - Pg. 61
All NPCs from the book in one place

GM Reference Sheets - Pg. 62
The Guidebook's Exploration Turn Reference Card applied

Your First Session

You need less prep than you think. Read the Thornwall home base section, the Settled Ring hexes (01-10), and the Forest encounter table. That's it. Everything else can wait.

Session 1 starts at the Antler & Axe. The party has just arrived in Thornwall. Joss Kettleburn greets them, pours drinks, and points at the rumor board. Let them read the three entries and pick one. That choice is the session.

Harsk Deepwell is at the bar. He walks over, introduces himself, and offers a job: scout the eastern canyon (Hex 06) and bring back a copper sample. He pays up front, half now. This is the default first hook if your players don't bite on anything from the rumor board.

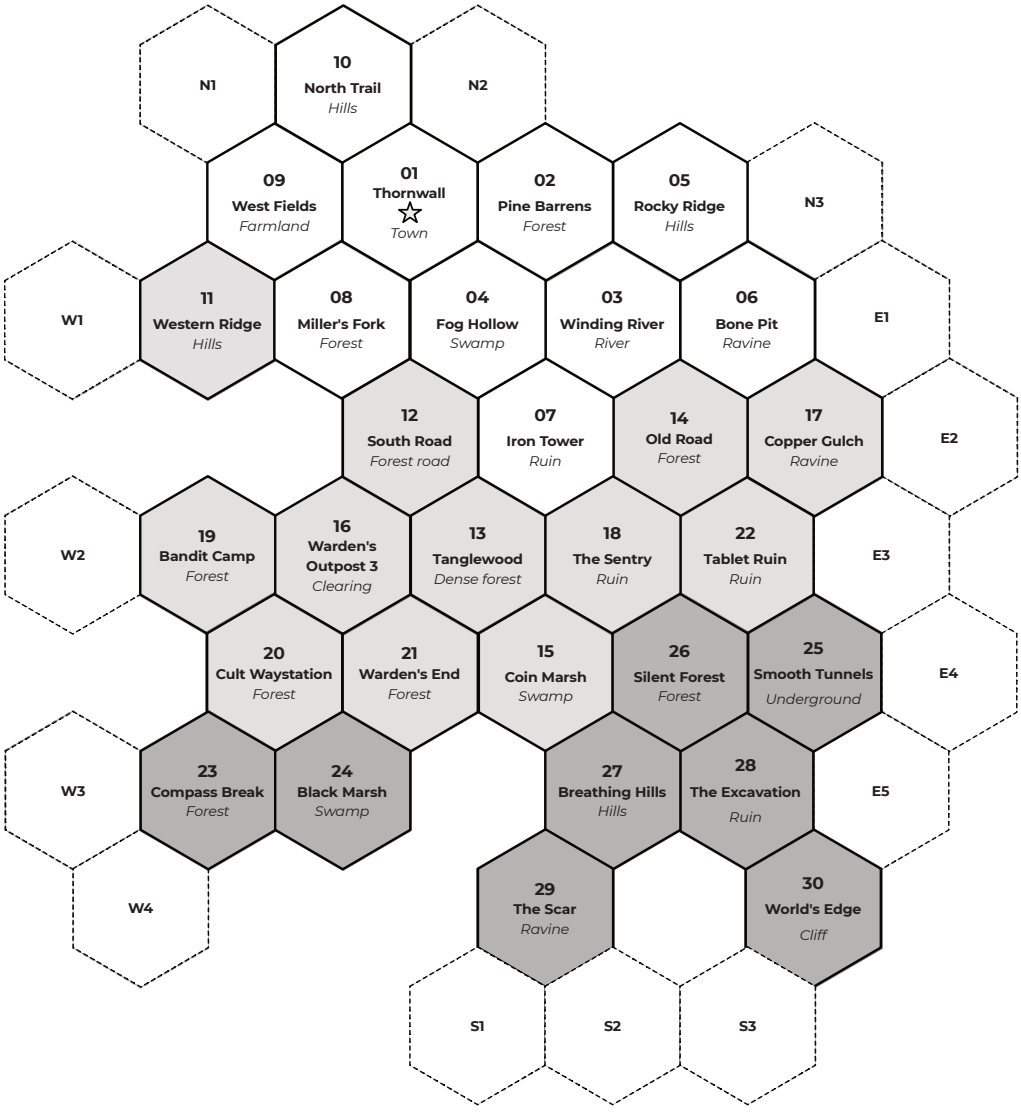
The first decision point comes at Hex 02. The party finds a journal in an abandoned camp pointing to Hex 06. Do they follow the journal's route or stick to the job Harsk gave them? Either way, they're exploring.

Keep the GM Reference Sheet open. Roll encounters when the procedure tells you to. When the party returns to Thornwall with something to sell or report, Harsk buys, Joss asks for the story, and a new rumor goes up on the board. That loop is the game.

Don't prep past the Settled Ring for session 1. The Frontier can wait until your players point at it and say "what's over there?"

Throughout this module, boxed text connects specific content back to the principles presented in the three Hexcrawl Guidebooks.

GM's Keyed Hex Map



The Thornwall Frontier: 30 keyed hexes across three zones. Print this page for reference during play.

Each hex is 6 miles across. The region spans roughly 40 miles east-west and 35 miles north-south. A party moving through open terrain crosses the region in about three days. Through forest and hills, closer to five.

Region Summary

Central tension: Thornwall sits on the edge of a frontier that's becoming profitable. Copper, timber, and salvageable ruins draw miners deeper every season. But something old lives in the deep places, and the people who've guarded the frontier for generations say the digging should stop.

Terrain: Pine forests and farmland near Thornwall, rising to rocky hills and river valleys in the middle distance, giving way to dense old-growth forest, swamp, and eroded canyon lands at the edges.

Tone: Grounded and familiar near town. Wilder and more contested in the middle ring. Strange and old at the deep edges. The tonal shift is deliberate: your players should feel it. I've found that players start asking different questions once they cross into the Frontier. That shift tells you the zone design is working.

The Below: Something is active under the frontier. It doesn't announce itself. Players will notice it through effects: compass needles that swing toward the excavation site past Hex 23, stone that's warm to the touch where no fire has burned, a low vibration felt through boot soles in the Deep, and animals behaving wrong. The effects get stronger as the party moves deeper and as the Cult's excavation progresses.

Three factions pull the frontier in different directions. Two work in the open. One hides.

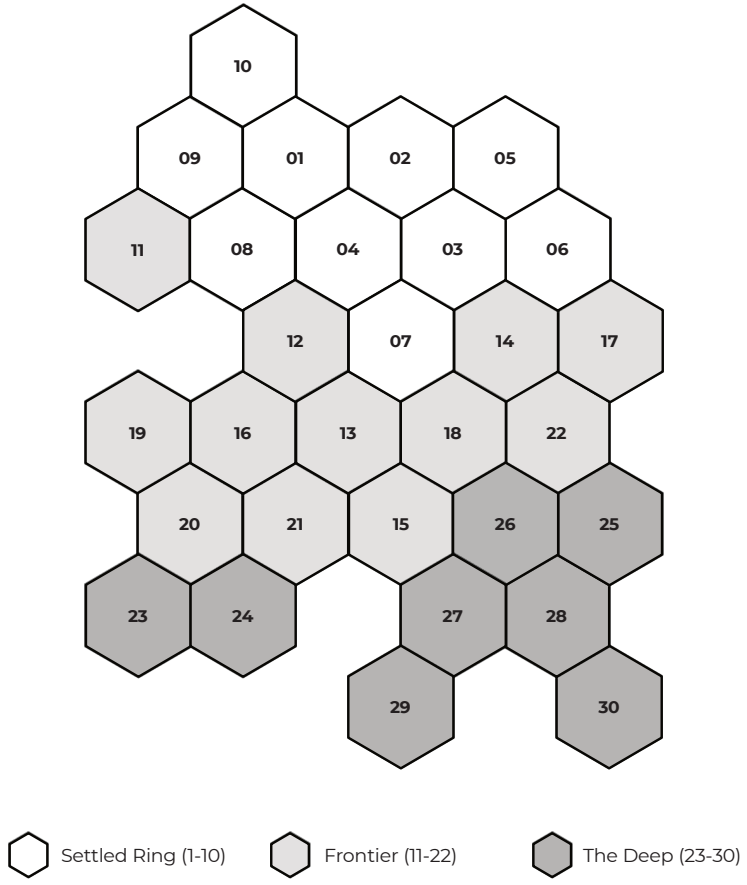
- **Thornwall Miners' Guild.** Push deeper, find more, profit. The force drawing people toward the deep.
- **The Grey Wardens.** Hold the line, patrol the frontier, keep people out. The force keeping people back.
- **The Bone Cult.** Excavate and awaken what sleeps below. Hidden. The party learns about them last.

The Three Zones

Settled Ring (Hexes 01-10): Farmland, trade roads, pine forests. Dangers are mundane: wolves, bandits, weather. Miners' Guild territory. Run the first few sessions here. I budget two to three sessions before anyone crosses into the Frontier.

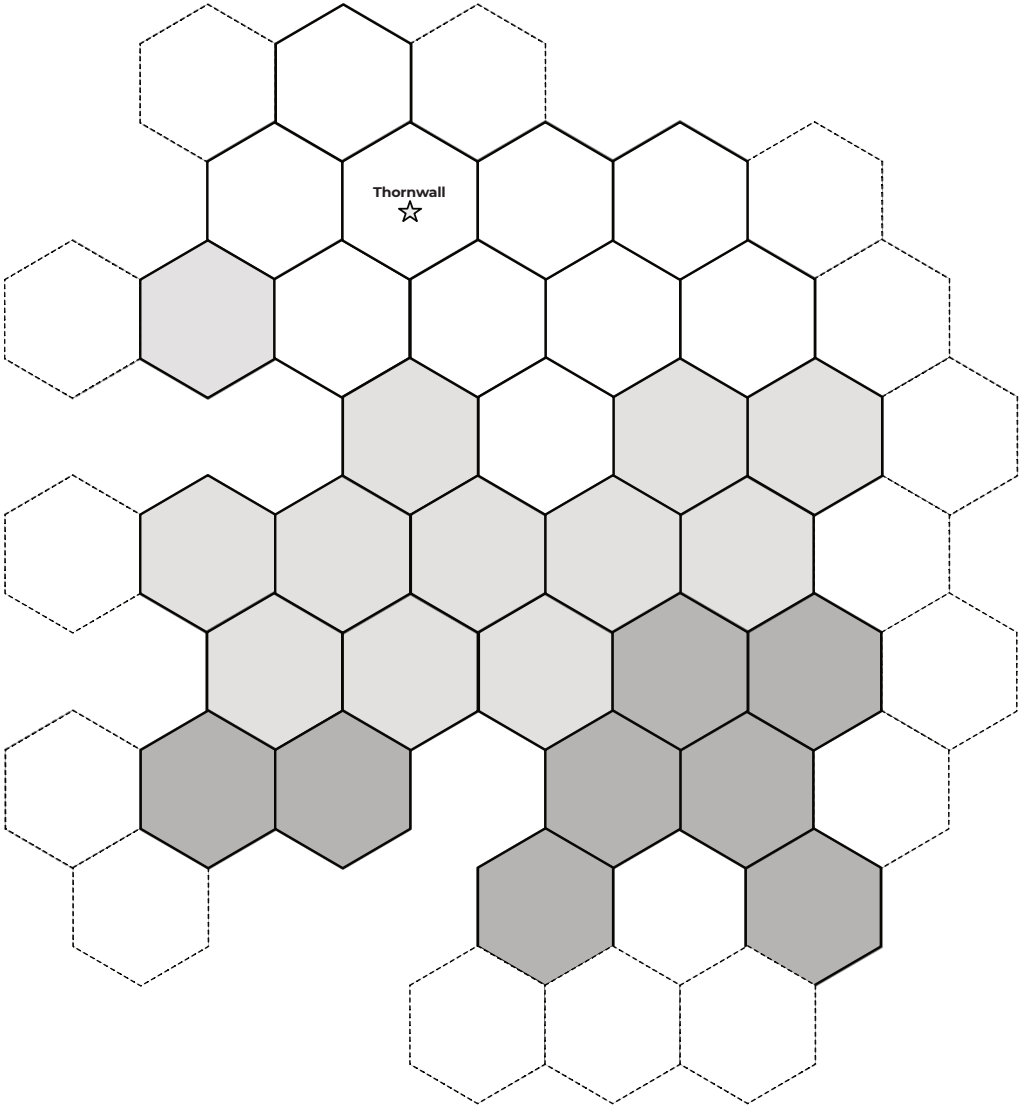
The Frontier (Hexes 11-22): Ruins, contested territory, faction tensions. Warden patrol markers and Cult symbols scratched on stones. Encounters get more varied and faction pressure starts to build.

The Deep (Hexes 23-30): Old magic, inhuman architecture, environmental hazards that break the rules. The Bone Cult's heartland. Something is waking up here.



Player Map

Player Map. No hex numbers, no keys, no spoilers.

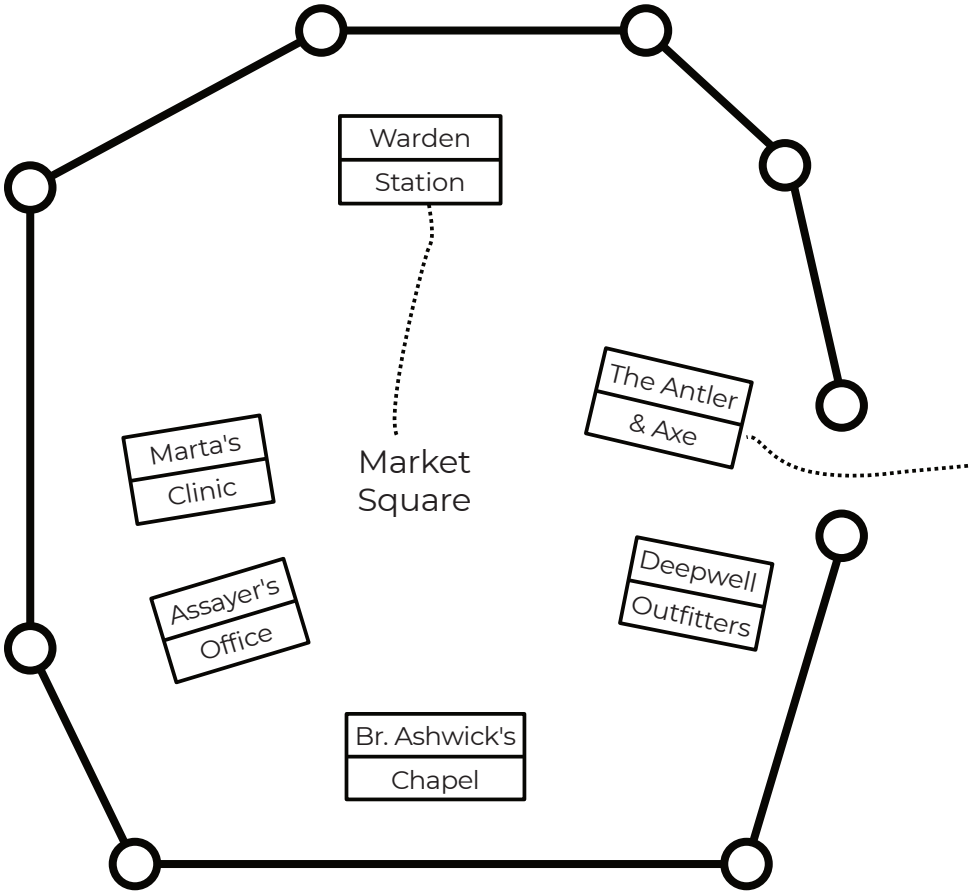


Photocopy or screenshot this page for your players. They fill it in as they explore.

Thornwall

Home Base

Mud-brick town on a ridge overlooking the frontier. Two hundred people, mostly miners, trappers, and the people who sell them things. A timber palisade surrounds the market square. The gate faces east, toward the untamed frontier.



Thornwall town layout. Mud-brick town on a ridge overlooking the frontier.

A home base needs services, NPCs with agendas, and a reason to leave.

Thornwall exists to service expeditions. Players should want to leave it and come back to it, not linger. A typical five-session stretch looks like this: session 1 starts in town (pick a job, buy gear, leave by midday), sessions 2 through 4 are in the field, and session 5 ends back in town to sell, report, and pick the next job. Town time is the frame, not the painting itself.

A laborer earns 1 silver a day. A week's rations costs 5 silver. Three hundred silver is a small fortune in Thornwall. Use these as your baseline when the party asks what something is worth or whether they can afford it.

Harsk buys copper ore at 5 silver per sample bag. A confirmed vein location is worth 20 silver. Unusual ore (traces he can't identify) is worth negotiating over.

Quick price list:

- A night at the Antler & Axe costs 1 silver.
- A healing visit to Marta costs 2 silver (serious injuries, more).
- A replacement pick or shovel runs 3 silver.
- Hiring a local porter for a day costs 2 silver plus food.

The job board at the Antler & Axe is the central hub for leads. Harsk, Voss, and other NPCs also offer jobs directly. When players ask 'what's there to do,' point them at the board first.

Worldbuilding Guidebook, Settlement Card: Thornwall's baseline mood is "practical and exposed." The town exists to service expeditions, not to be a destination. This is a BUILD-phase settlement: name, mood, three services, two NPCs with agendas.

Services

Six locations cover what a party needs between expeditions. Prices above are suggestions. Adjust to your system and your party's level.

- **The Antler & Axe (tavern and inn).** Beds, hot food, cold beer. Job board by the front door. This is where expeditions are planned.
- **Marta's Clinic.** Healing, herbal remedies, bone-setting. Marta treats anyone, no questions asked.
- **Deepwell Outfitters.** Rations, rope, torches, picks, shovels. Standard adventuring gear at fair prices. Deepwell Outfitters stocks basic weapons: hand axes, hunting knives, shortbows, and clubs. Nothing forged for war. For proper swords and armor, the nearest weaponsmith is two days west. Harsk runs it when he's in town. His assistant handles sales when Harsk is out with a mining expedition.
- **The Assayer's Office.** Evaluates ore samples, maps, and salvaged goods, and sets prices for what they're worth. Posts bounties for specific finds.
- **Warden Station.** Small stone building at the north end of town. Captain Voss posts notices here: trail closures, sightings, warnings.
- **Br. Ashwick's Chapel.** A small shrine by the south wall, opened a month ago by the itinerant priest. Blessings, a quiet place to talk, and a lot of questions about the deep country.



Thornwall NPCs

Thornwall has eight NPCs the party will talk to regularly. Each one knows something the party needs and will share a piece of it per conversation. Treat them as information dispensers with personalities: the party comes back to town, talks to two or three, and leaves with new leads.

Harsk Deepwell — Miners' Guild leader

Pragmatic ex-miner, mid-50s, missing two fingers on his left hand. Friendly and direct. Hires the party for scouting and retrieval jobs. Knows the settled ring better than anyone alive. Doesn't believe in curses.

What Harsk knows:

1. Every mining trail in the Settled Ring, including two that predate Thornwall's founding
2. The location and rough yield of the copper vein in Hex 06, confirmed by personal survey
3. Which ore samples Sera Lindt has flagged as unusual (she told him, but he's pretending otherwise)
4. That the tunnel in Hex 06 goes deeper than any natural copper deposit should

Captain Elara Voss — Grey Wardens

Commands the remaining four rangers. Late 30s, lean, watchful. Speaks carefully. Will share information if the party proves trustworthy, but only if they ask. Carries a journal with patrol routes dating back forty years.

What Voss knows:

1. All current Warden patrol routes through the Frontier (Hexes 11-22), including which ones are now unmonitored
2. The patrol journals from forty years of Warden records, including two previous incidents near Hex 28 that were never fully documented

3. That Brother Ashwick is almost certainly Bone Cult. She has three pieces of circumstantial evidence and needs one more
4. The location of Hex 28 by name, and that two of her rangers went missing investigating digging sounds nearby

Marta Greaves healer

Thornwall's only medical practitioner. Old, sharp-tongued, knows everyone's business. She works with herbal remedies, splints, and tinctures. No magic. Recovery takes days, not minutes. Treats anyone, no questions asked. Her clinic has a back room where she keeps specimens: strange bones, discolored water samples, plants that shouldn't grow this far north.

What Marta knows:

1. Which injuries come from animal attacks and which come from something else. She's been tracking a pattern.
2. That plants from the deep country have unusual properties. She's growing three specimens in her back room.
3. Who in town is hiding injuries. She sees everyone eventually.

Joss Kettleburn innkeeper, Antler & Axe

Cheerful, loud, collects stories. Manages the job board. Will extend credit to people who bring back good tales.

What Joss knows:

1. Which miners left town this week and which ones haven't come back
2. Every rumor that's crossed his bar in the last month, including the ones he didn't post on the board
3. That Old Tam's story about the excavation site matches details from two other sources

Sera Lindt assayer, ore and salvage evaluator

Quiet, precise, slightly nervous. Evaluates finds and sets bounties. Hasn't told anyone that the ore samples from the deep sites contain traces she can't identify. She's worried about what it means.

What Sera knows:

1. That ore samples from deeper sites contain mineral traces she can't identify
2. The exact value of every type of find in the region, and who's been selling what
3. That the copper in Hex 06 has trace metals that don't occur naturally in this geology

Old Tam retired miner

Sits by the tavern fire every night. Claims to have been deeper into the frontier than anyone living. Most of his stories are exaggerated. One of them isn't.

What Old Tam knows:

1. The location of the excavation site. He saw it decades ago, before the Bone Cult found it.
2. That the deep country used to be quieter. It got worse in the last few years.
3. A route through the swamps that avoids the worst ground. He won't share it for free.

Wren Warden ranger

Youngest of Voss's four rangers. Eager, talkative, frequently posted at the town gate. The easiest Warden to get information from, though she doesn't always know what's classified.

What Wren knows:

1. Current patrol schedules and which trails are being watched this week
2. That two rangers went south three weeks ago and haven't reported back
3. Gossip from the gate: who's arriving, who's leaving, and who's been asking about the deep country

Brother Ashwick itinerant priest

Arrived in Thornwall a month ago. Mild-mannered, asks a lot of questions about the deep country. He is not what he seems. (Bone Cult contact, gathering intelligence. Voss suspects but can't prove it.)

What Ashwick knows (GM only):

1. The layout of the ruins near Hex 28, pieced together from *"scholarly conversations"*
2. That the Wardens are stretched thin and can't cover the southern trails
3. Which party members seem easiest to recruit or mislead

Three questions Ashwick asks
(always casual, always in the context of friendly tavern conversation):

1. *"I heard you went east of the river. Did you see any old stonework out there? I have a scholarly interest in the ruins."*
   (Wants: confirmation the ruins in Hex 28 are accessible)
2. *"The Wardens seem to keep people away from the southern trails. Do you know what they're worried about?"*
   (Wants: Warden patrol gaps he can exploit)
3. *"A miner told me the compass acts strange past the old watchtower. Did you notice anything like that?"*
   (Wants: signs that the chamber is active)

Job Board

Pinned to the wall inside the Antler & Axe. Three entries are up when the party arrives:

1. *"Copper vein spotted in the eastern canyon. Harsk paying double for confirmed samples."* → Hex 06 (posted by Harsk)
2. *"Warden patrol found fresh tracks on the old road. Something big, walking on two legs."* → Hex 14 (posted by Voss)
3. *"A trapper says there's a stone tower two to three days southeast. Lights in the windows at night."* → Hex 07 (posted by Joss)

- **Harsk** adds entries when a mining expedition returns with a find or a lead.
- **Joss** adds entries when a traveler pays for a drink with information.

After each session in which the party returns to Thornwall, add at least one new entry pointing to a hex they haven't visited.

Rewards. Match pay to risk. Jobs in the Settled Ring pay 50 to 100 silver. Frontier jobs pay 100 to 200. Deep jobs pay 200 to 300, if anyone is foolish enough to post one. Harsk pays in coin. Voss pays in information and trail access. Joss pays in credit at the bar, which is worth more than it sounds.

Rival prospectors. The party is not the only group working the frontier. A crew of four led by a woman named Dalva arrived two weeks before the party. They take jobs from the board, sell finds to Sera, and drink at the Antler & Axe. They are not hostile, but they are competitive.

When the party returns to Thornwall, roll a d6:

- **On a 1:** Dalva's crew got to a job first and the board entry is crossed out.
- **On a 2:** they're in the tavern and have information to trade.

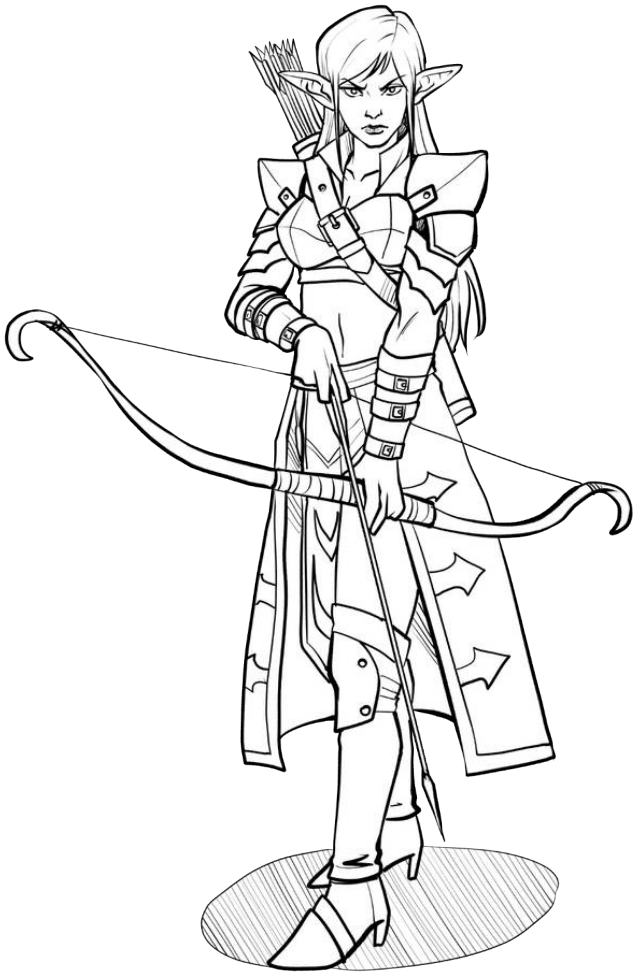
Use them as a pressure valve: if the party is taking too long to follow a lead, Dalva's crew follows it instead. You can also encounter them in the field. They appear on the Faction Encounters table.

New entries
(add these after the first session, or when the party returns to town):

1. *"Merchant caravan hasn't arrived from the south. Two weeks overdue."* → Hex 12 (posted by Joss)

2. *"Strange carvings in the canyon walls. Miners say they weren't there last season."* → Hex 25 (posted by Harsk)

3. *"Someone stole supplies from the Warden station. Voss is furious but won't say what was taken."* → Hex 20 (posted by Wren)



Factions

Factions act between sessions whether the party is watching or not.

Thornwall Miners' Guild. Referred to as "the Guild" from here on

Leader: Harsk Deepwell

Goal: Push deeper into the frontier for copper, timber, and ruin salvage

Resources: 15-20 active miners, mules, basic tools, the Assayer's Office, and Thornwall's economic support. Ore and salvage go north to Ashford by caravan. That's also how the party got here.

Territory: The Settled Ring (Hexes 01-10), with scouting parties pushing into the Frontier

Attitude: Friendly

Current action: Harsk is organizing a major expedition to the eastern canyons (Hex 06 and beyond). He needs scouts and guards. The party is an obvious hire.

First contact: Harsk approaches the party in the Antler & Axe on their first night in town, buys a round, and offers work before they've finished their drinks.

If ignored for 3 sessions: The Miners' Guild pushes east without the party. A prospecting crew goes missing near Hex 17. Harsk offers a rescue bounty.

The Grey Wardens. Referred to as "the Wardens" from here on

Leader: Captain Elara Voss

Goal: Keep people out of the deep places so nothing down there gets disturbed. Their predecessors learned the hard way what happens when someone digs too deep. Maintain the patrol routes that keep the boundary.

Resources: Four rangers (down from twenty a generation ago, and two of those four are currently missing on patrol), a stone station in Thornwall, cached supplies along patrol routes, and forty years of patrol logs that Voss has memorized

Territory: Patrol routes through the Frontier (Hexes 11-22), with patrol posts at key positions

Attitude: Wary

Current action: Voss is investigating disappearances along the southern trail. She suspects the Bone Cult but lacks proof. She'll ask the party for help if they earn her trust.

First contact: Voss doesn't approach the party until they've completed at least one job in the Frontier or brought back intelligence she can verify, typically session 2 or 3.

If ignored for 3 sessions: Voss pulls her rangers back to a defensive perimeter. The Frontier patrol routes go unmonitored. Encounters in Hexes 11-22 get worse.

The Bone Cult Referred to as "the Cult" from here on

Leader: The Sexton (never seen unmasked)

Goal: Excavate the deep ruins and awaken what sleeps there. They believe it's a power that will transform the world. They're right that a presence lingers there. They're wrong about what it wants.

Resources: 8-12 devoted members, an excavation camp in the Deep (Hex 28), stolen Warden supplies, and fragments of old texts that describe the Below

Territory: The Deep (Hexes 23-30), with informants in Thornwall

Attitude: Hidden

Current action: The excavation is progressing. The Sexton has found a sealed chamber and is working to open it. Cult members are scavenging the Frontier for tools and supplies, leaving symbols scratched on stones as waymarkers.

First contact: Brother Ashwick sits down at the party's table in the Antler & Axe after their first expedition, making casual conversation about where they went and what they saw.

If ignored for 3 sessions: The sealed chamber opens. Something changes in the Deep: compass needles drift, animals flee, dreams come to anyone sleeping within 3 hexes. The Wardens notice and escalate.

If all three factions are ignored from the start

- The Miners' Guild pushes east and a crew goes missing (session 3).
- Voss pulls her rangers back to Thornwall and the Frontier goes unmonitored (session 4).
- The Cult opens the chamber (session 5).

These three clocks compound: a frontier with no Warden patrols, a missing crew somewhere in the Deep, and whatever the Cult has awakened now operating without opposition. The party walks into a region that has moved on without them.

Worldbuilding Guidebook, Faction Card (MAINTAIN phase): Each faction here has a 10-minute between-session update: advance their goal one step, check whether the party changed anything, adjust attitude. That's the MAINTAIN loop in action.

This is compound escalation: three independent faction clocks running simultaneously. See the Guidebook, chapter 5.

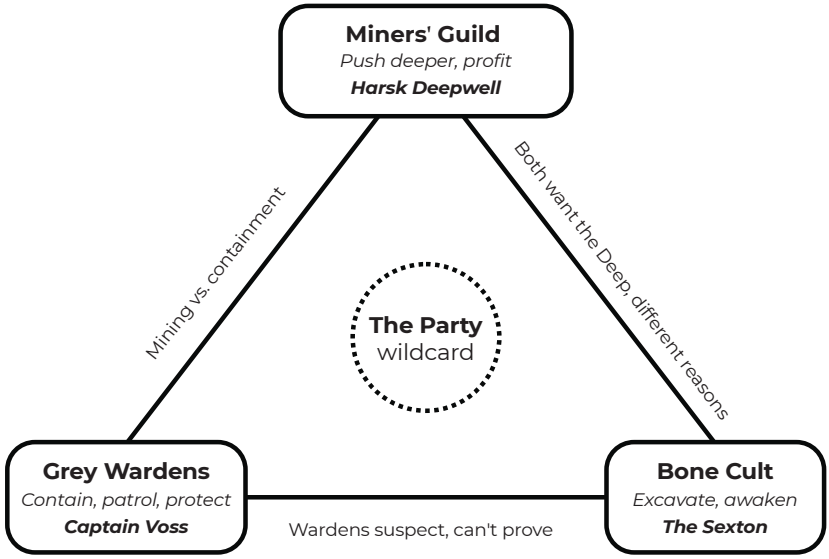
The "Old Thing" named "the Below" by Wardens, "the Sleeper" by the Cult

It's described through effects, not exposition:

- Dreams near certain hexes: images of dark water, stone corridors, a sound like breathing
- Stone that's warm to the touch where it shouldn't be
- Compass needles drifting toward the excavation site instead of north
- Animals behaving wrong: birds circling in silence, deer standing motionless in clearings
- A low vibration felt through boot soles, strongest in the Deep

What it actually is: the module gives you the effects, the clues, and the factions' interpretations. What's at the bottom of the excavation is yours to fill in, or leave blank.

The sealed chamber in Hex 28 is the closest the party can get. What happens when they reach it depends on whether the Cult has opened it first. If you want a confrontation, put one there. If you want mystery, leave the chamber sealed and let the effects speak for themselves.



Encounter Tables

Every entry below creates a decision or reveals the world. None of them are just a monster in a room.

Encounter frequency increases by zone.

- In the Settled Ring, you check once per watch and trigger on a 1 (on d6).
- In the Frontier, encounters trigger on 1-2.
- In the Deep, 1-3.

A Settled Ring session typically produces 1-2 encounters, Frontier sessions run 2-3, and Deep sessions may hit 3-4.

Quality beats quantity: one tense encounter that changes the party's plans is worth more than three forgettable ones.

The tables below are organized by terrain type, not by zone. Roll on the table matching the hex's terrain. Most tables apply across all three zones. Tone and threat level come from the zone, not the table: a wolf pack in the Settled Ring is a nuisance, the same roll in the Deep is a desperate fight.

Using These Tables

Signs vs. encounters. Some entries are encounters (you meet someone, something attacks, a decision is forced). Others are signs (tracks, marks, remains, environmental clues). Signs build tension without forcing a confrontation. When you roll a sign, play it as atmosphere: describe it, let the party react, move on. Don't force a fight from a set of old claw marks.

> **Encounter Design Guidebook, Signs and Encounters**: About 60% of table entries here are signs, not direct confrontations. The 60/40 ratio keeps tension high without exhausting the party through constant combat.
>
> **Encounter Design Guidebook, Encounter Trifecta**: Each table entry follows the trifecta pattern: a hook (what the party notices), a decision (what they choose to do about it), and a consequence (what changes because of that choice).

Forest (d8)

#	Encounter
1	Wolf pack (4-6) trailing a wounded elk. They'll ignore the party unless someone gets between them and their prey. Killing the elk first turns the pack hostile. Letting them feed buys safe passage through the hex.
2	Abandoned campsite. Fire still hot. Gear scattered as if the occupants left in a hurry. Tracks lead toward the nearest Frontier hex. Following them costs one watch and reveals a second campsite, also abandoned, with a Bone Cult symbol scratched on a rock.
3	Trapper checking snare lines. Knows the local trails. Will trade information for a share of rations or a favor. Roll on the Rumors table (page 30) for what they know.
4	Dense fog rolls in. Visibility drops to 30 feet. Navigation checks are harder. The fog lifts after one watch.
5	A tree scored with claw marks at shoulder height. Fresh sap still running. The creature that did this is large and territorial. The marks are fresh enough that it's still in the hex. Move quiet or risk meeting it.
6	A clearing with a collapsed root cellar. Inside: rusted tools, a rotted journal, and a hand-drawn map pointing to a hex the party hasn't visited.
7	Miners (3) heading back to Thornwall. One has a deep cut on his arm that he says came from a fall, but it looks deliberate. They found old bones arranged in a circle and won't talk about it.
8	Distant sound of chopping. A lone woodcutter, nervous, working fast. Says the Wardens ordered everyone out of this area. He doesn't know why.

Hills (d8)

#	Encounter
1	Rockslide blocks the path. A quick climb to get over (no time cost) or one watch to find a route around. Climbing risks a twisted ankle.
2	A stone trail sign with a Warden tag. Patrol route notation: date, initials, "all clear." The date is three months old. Three months without a patrol means the route is unmonitored. The party can move freely here, but so can anyone else.
3	Mountain goats on a ledge above. Not hostile, but their calls echo and attract attention. The noise makes the next encounter more likely: add 1 to the d6 roll. Scattering them takes a risky climb. Waiting costs a watch. Pushing through means anything that heard them heard you too.
4	A vein of copper ore exposed by erosion. Harsk would pay well for a sample and the location.
5	Bandits (3-4) camped in a rocky overhang. Deserters from a southern militia. Desperate, willing to talk before fighting.
6	A vantage point. If the sky is clear, you can see two hexes in every direction. Name what's visible from the GM map.
7	Wind picks up hard. Exposed positions become dangerous. Make camp or descend, or risk gear damage.
8	Bones of a creature with teeth the size of daggers, half-buried in loose rock. Old bones, but fresh scoring on the ribs: a predator did this, not a scavenger. The killer still hunts these hills.

Swamp (d8)

#	Encounter
1	Clinging mud. Lead traveler sinks to the knee. Takes a watch to extract safely, or risk losing a boot.
2	Will-o'-wisps: lights drifting over the water. Following them leads deeper into the swamp. Ignoring them is wise.
3	A dead miner, face-down in shallow water. Gear intact. Cause of death: something bit through his boot. No tracks. His journal lists three hexes with ore samples. The last entry is coordinates and the word 'below.'
4	Thick cloud of biting insects. Miserable. Anyone who pushes through without covering up risks fever by the next morning. Moving fast reduces exposure but burns an extra ration. Waiting them out costs a watch.
5	An island of dry ground with a standing stone. Touching it brings a flash of dizziness and a one-second vision of a vaulted chamber underground.
6	Giant leeches (2-3) in the water. Not deadly but disgusting. Each one drains enough blood to leave a character weakened for the rest of the day. Burn one extra ration to recover.
7	The sound of chanting, distant, carried on the wind. Stops when listened for. Starts again when you move on. Following the sound leads to a ring of stones in a flooded clearing. Fresh candle stubs and bone fragments on the ground. Whoever was here left recently.
8	A half-submerged wooden platform: remnant of an old bridge or dock. Leads nowhere now, but carved symbols on the posts match ones seen in Hex 25.

Ruins (d8)

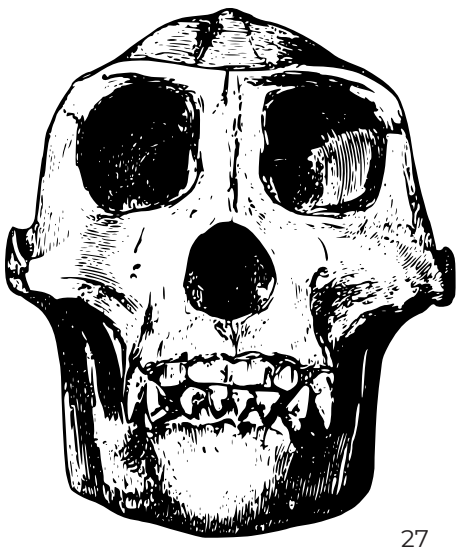
#	Encounter
1	Loose masonry collapses underfoot. Save or take a bruising fall. The hole reveals a lower level nobody knew about.
2	Cult symbols scratched into a wall. Fresh. Someone has been here in the last few days. Camping here risks a Cult visit before dawn. Moving to the next hex costs half a watch.
3	A locked iron door, still intact despite centuries. Hot to the touch. A hum behind it, felt more than heard. Forcing it is loud. Picking it takes time and tools. The hum responds to knocking.
4	Nesting birds scatter as you enter. Droppings cover everything, but beneath it: a mosaic floor depicting a map of the region. Some details don't match the current landscape.
5	A Warden cache: rations, rope, a letter in a wax-stopped tube. The letter is addressed to "whoever finds this" and describes a patrol that never returned.
6	The air is wrong. It shimmers faintly, carrying a mineral smell. Prolonged exposure brings drowsiness. Pushing through quickly avoids the worst of it. Investigating the source costs a watch but reveals a locked workshop.
7	Something moved in the shadows. You're sure of it. But when you check, nothing. Tracks in the dust confirm something was here minutes ago. The tracks lead deeper into the ruin and down. Following them costs a watch and a torch.
8	A stone basin filled with clear water that shouldn't exist in a dry ruin. Drinking it tastes of copper and brings vivid dreams at the next rest.

Universal Fallback (d6)

Use when no terrain table fits or when you need an encounter fast:

#	Encounter
1	Weather shifts. Roll on the weather table or choose: rain, fog, wind, sudden cold.
2	Tracks. Something passed through here recently. Size and direction tell a story. Following it adds half a watch but reveals who else uses this route.
3	A traveler. NPC heading somewhere with a reason. Reaction roll determines disposition.
4	Signs of a camp. Someone stayed here. What they left behind is a clue.
5	Animal behavior. Something spooked the local wildlife. Silence, or flight, or aggression.
6	Discovery. A natural feature, a forgotten object, a view. Something worth noting on the map.

When a table starts producing results your group has already seen, combine two rolls from different tables into one encounter (a trapper in the swamp, bandits in the ruins) or add a faction element: the wolf pack wears a collar with a Warden tag, the abandoned campsite has Cult symbols scratched into a cookpot.



Farmland (d6)

#	Encounter
1	Farmer on the road, cart loaded with grain for Thornwall. Talkative. Has seen something on the ridge at night but doesn't want to say what.
2	A field boundary marker knocked over. Deliberate. Neighbor dispute, or someone cut through the fields at night and didn't care about the damage.
3	Grazing cattle scatter as the party approaches. One of them has a brand nobody recognizes. It's not from any local farm.
4	A root cellar with the door standing open. Inside: empty shelves, a broken lantern, and boot prints that don't match the farmer's. Someone stashed something here and came back for it.
5	Smoke on the horizon. A hay barn burning. The farmer blames lightning. There was no storm last night.
6	A Warden trail marker at a field edge, pointing south. The notation reads "watch line" with last week's date. Voss is extending patrol coverage closer to Thornwall. That means she thinks the threat is moving north.

Night. These tables assume daylight. At night, shift the tone: the trapper is nervous and armed, the fog is disorienting instead of inconvenient, the Cult runner is bolder. Animals are more aggressive after dark. Signs are harder to read but easier to miss, which makes stumbling on one more alarming. In the Deep, night encounters are worse across the board: compass drift intensifies, the vibration through boot soles is stronger, and anything that moves in the shadows is closer than it sounds.

Faction Encounters (d8)

Use when faction pressure is rising, or when the party is in territory a faction claims. Roll or choose based on the zone.

#	Zone	Encounter
1	Settled Ring	Guild mining crew (3-4) heading out with mules and tools. Will share trail conditions for news of what's east.
2	Settled Ring	Warden ranger re-marking trail posts. Tight-lipped about why patrol routes are changing.
3	Settled/Frontier	Dalva's crew (4) working a site the party planned to visit. They've already found something and are deciding whether to share information or keep the advantage.
4	Frontier	Cult runner moving fast through rough terrain. Carries a sealed message tube. Avoids contact, fights only if cornered.
5	Frontier	Warden patrol (2) investigating a report. Will question the party about what they've seen south of here.
6	Deep	Cult excavation team (3-4) hauling stolen Warden supplies. Hostile if recognized, otherwise pose as miners.
7	Deep	Warden scout, alone, far from patrol routes. Looking for the two missing rangers. Exhausted, grateful for any help.
8	Any	Dalva's crew (4) camped at a trail junction, comparing notes over a fire. They've mapped hexes the party hasn't visited and will trade information for information. If relations are good, Dalva warns them about something she saw two hexes south.

Rumors (d12)

Every rumor points to a hex. Rumors are the party's navigation system: they choose where to go based on what they've heard.

#	Source	Rumor	Truth	Hex
1	Tavern talk	"Copper in the eastern canyons. Harsk says it's the biggest vein in a decade."	True	06
2	Tavern talk	"The old bridge washed out years ago, but I heard there's trade goods in a wagon stuck in the riverbed."	True	03
3	Miner	"We found tunnels under the ridge. Not natural. Walls are smooth, like something melted through the rock."	True	25
4	Warden	"We sealed that tower for a reason. Whatever Harsk tells you, stay out of it."	Partial	07
5	Warden	"The southern trail isn't safe anymore. We lost contact with outpost 3."	True	16
6	Tavern talk	"A merchant named Collier went south two weeks ago with a full wagon. Nobody's seen him since."	True	12
7	Whispered	"Brother Ashwick asks too many questions about the deep country. He's not here to pray."	True	01
8	Tavern talk	"Old Tam says there's a city under the hills. He's drunk, but he says it every night and the details never change."	Partial	25
9	Warden	"We've been finding symbols scratched on trail markers. Deliberate. Someone is mapping our patrol routes."	True	20
10	Whispered	"Compasses don't work right past the old watchtower. Point toward the excavation site instead of north."	True	23
11	Tavern talk	"A trapper found silver coins in the swamp. Old ones, with faces nobody recognized."	True	15
12	Whispered	"Something is different in the deep forest. The birds stopped singing three weeks ago."	True	26

Quest Lines

Four ready-made quest lines, each spanning multiple hexes. Use them as starting points, mid-campaign hooks, or fallbacks when the party needs direction. Each quest lists the hexes involved in likely order, but players will find their own route. I find rescue missions work best as the party's first quest. The stakes are clear, the clock is real, and the trail teaches them how to read the map.



The Missing Caravan

Merchant Collier (plump, sweaty, talks too fast when nervous) left Thornwall heading south with supplies for a settlement that no longer exists. His wagon was last seen on the south road (Hex 12). The trail leads through Warden territory (Hex 16) and into the contested Frontier. Harsk wants the trade goods recovered. Voss wants to know what happened to the road. The answer involves bandits (Hex 19), a washed-out bridge, and a Cult supply cache that Collier stumbled into (Hex 20).

Hexes: 12 → 16 → 19 → 20

The Silent Outpost

Warden Outpost 3 (Hex 16) missed its scheduled signal three days ago. Captain Voss can't spare rangers to investigate. She'll ask the party if they've proven reliable. The outpost is intact but abandoned. Gear is packed neatly. The patrol log's last entry: "Heard digging southwest. Investigating at dawn. Back by nightfall." A trail leads southwest toward the Deep (Hex 21 → Hex 24).

Hexes: 16 → 21 → 24

Deep Copper

Harsk has confirmed a major copper deposit in the eastern canyons (Hex 06), but the survey team reported "structural anomalies" underground. He needs someone to map the tunnels below the deposit before he commits a full mining crew. The tunnels connect through Copper Gulch (Hex 17) to the Smooth Tunnels (Hex 25). The tunnels are older than any human construction in the region. They go deeper than a copper mine should. The walls are hot against the palm.

Hexes: 06 → 17 → 25

The Sexton's Offer

If the party gains a reputation, Brother Ashwick approaches with a job: retrieve a stone tablet from a ruin in Hex 22. He claims it's a religious artifact. The tablet is real, and the ruin is worth exploring. But the tablet is a key, not a relic, and delivering it to Ashwick accelerates the Bone Cult's excavation. The party won't know this unless they can read the inscription or get Voss to examine it.

Hexes: 22 → 28 (if delivered)

THE SETTLED RING

Hexes 01-10. Farmland, pine forests, trade roads. Mundane dangers. Run sessions 1-3 here.

Hex 01: Thornwall (town) *bustling*

Home base. See the Thornwall home base section above for full details. Mud-brick town on a ridge, palisade walls, market square, the Antler & Axe. The map has one hub, and this is it.

→ All roads lead here. Hex 02 (east), Hex 08 (south), Hex 09 (west), Hex 10 (north).

Hex 02: Pine Barrens (forest) *quiet*

Sparse pines over sandy soil. Half a day east of Thornwall on a well-worn trail. An abandoned camp sits in a clearing: cold fire pit, locked chest, no sign of violence. The chest contains a leather journal. Entries describe prospecting routes east, but the final pages shift tone. The writer found a stone tower two days southeast and sketched its location. Last entry, three weeks ago: 'Going back to the tower. Lights again last night.' (Hex 07)

Under the journal: a cloth pouch with 8 silver coins and a small copper ore sample wrapped in oilcloth, labeled "east canyon, confirm." Worth a few days' rations to the Assayer. Worth considerably more to Harsk as proof that someone else found the vein first.

Deer trails crisscross the area. Nothing hostile. A party that camps here sleeps well and leaves in the morning wanting to know what's east.

→ Thornwall (Hex 01) west, Rocky Ridge (Hex 05) east, Fog Hollow (Hex 04) south. Journal points to Hex 07.

Campaign Playstyle Guidebook, Forward Pointers: The journal in this hex is a forward pointer. It gives the party a reason to visit Hex 07 before they know it exists. Every hex in the Settled Ring plants at least one pointer outward.

Hex 03: Winding River (river crossing) *exposed*

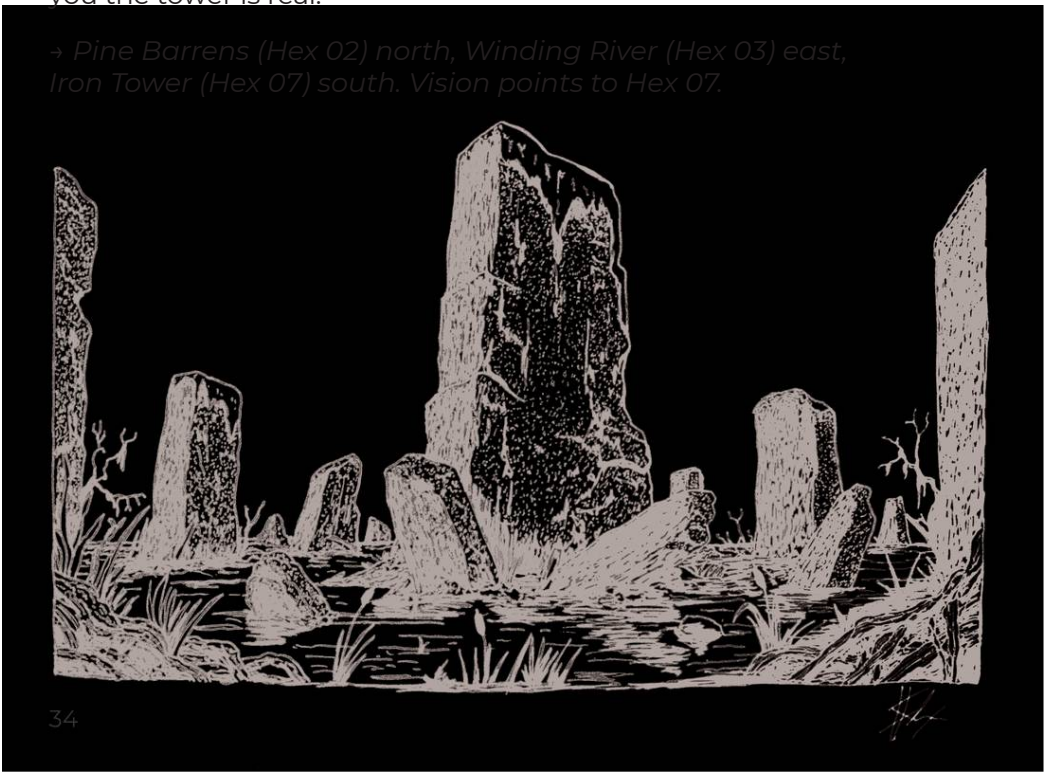
Collapsed stone bridge over a fast river. Waist-deep river crossing, treacherous footing on slippery stones. A submerged merchant wagon downstream holds thirty silver coins in waterlogged trade goods. Giant crayfish (2) nest under the bridge rubble: territorial but not aggressive unless someone disturbs their nest. Clacking sounds warn you off.

→ Hex 04 (west), Hex 06 (east), Hex 14 (south). The river runs north-south through multiple hexes.

Hex 04: Fog Hollow (swamp) *eerie*

Standing stones in ankle-deep water, wreathed in ground fog that never fully burns off. Leeches latch on and drain blood. Each watch spent here costs one extra ration to recover from the blood loss. No combat, but the cost rises the longer you linger. It's worth it: touching the central stone triggers a vision of a dark tower against a red sky (Hex 07). The vision lasts one heartbeat and leaves a metallic taste that tells you the tower is real.

→ Pine Barrens (Hex 02) north, Winding River (Hex 03) east, Iron Tower (Hex 07) south. Vision points to Hex 07.



Hex 05: Rocky Ridge (hills) *open*

High ground with long views in every direction. From the summit: smoke from Thornwall to the west, the river glinting to the south, dark tree line to the east, and on a clear day, a metallic flash on a hilltop far to the southeast (Hex 18). Sheltered campsite on the lee side. No water source on the ridge itself.

→ *Pine Barrens (Hex 02) west, Bone Pit (Hex 06) south, North Trail (Hex 10) north. Vantage reveals Hexes 01, 03, 18.*

If the party searches thoroughly (d4)

#	Discovery
1	Behind a loose slab on the summit, a Warden cache: a spyglass wrapped in oiled leather, still functional. With it, the metallic flash in Hex 18 resolves into a domed structure on the hilltop.
2	A narrow crevice on the south face leads to a sheltered overhang with old fire-marks and a scratched message: "Cult moves at new moon. Four carts. River road." Dated two months ago.
3	Wedged into a crack in the rock face, a copper surveyor's rod stamped with the same calendar marks as the Warden stone in Hex 27. Harsk will trade a day's rations for it.
4	The sheltered campsite has a buried firepit with charred bones. Someone butchered and cooked a large animal here recently. The cuts are precise, not the work of a hungry traveler. A trail of boot prints leads east toward Hex 06.

Vantage points let players see before they commit. This is information economy in action. See the Guidebook's Discovery and Exploration section.

Hex 06: Bone Pit (ravine) *ancient*

A ravine cut deep into limestone. Ancient fossils exposed in the cliff face: ribcages the size of wagons, teeth like stone blades. Giant bats roost in an overhang (moderate if disturbed by day, dangerous at night). A copper ore vein runs through the eastern wall. Valuable: Harsk will pay well for a confirmed sample and location.

At the ravine's north end, a narrow tunnel angles downward into darkness. Smooth walls, not natural. Unkeyed: I'd connect this to Hex 25. The smooth walls match, and letting the party find the tunnel system from below gives them a second approach to the Deep they didn't know existed.

→ *Rocky Ridge (Hex 05) north, Winding River (Hex 03) west, tunnel to Hex 25 (deep). Harsk's bounty points here.*

If the party searches thoroughly (d4)

#	Discovery
1	One of the fossilized ribcages contains a smaller skeleton curled inside it, not a second creature but something that crawled in after death. Its skull has copper deposits where the eyes were, the same ore as the vein in the eastern wall.
2	Behind a curtain of bat droppings, a painted section of cliff face shows a crude scene: stick figures fleeing upward from something below the ground. The paint is mineral-based and old beyond reckoning.
3	A tooth the size of a dagger, loose enough to pry free. Hard as steel, holds an edge. Worth good coin to a collector in Thornwall, or useful as an improvised weapon.
4	Near the tunnel entrance at the north end, a set of iron pitons hammered into the ravine wall. Old but solid. Someone made this descent often enough to install permanent handholds. The last piton has a scrap of rope still knotted to it, cut clean.

Hex 07: Iron Tower (ruin) *watchful*

Three-story stone tower, partially collapsed. Top floor open to sky. Signs of recent habitation: hot ashes in a ground-floor firepit, fresh scratches on the inner walls (claw marks, not tools). A locked basement door, iron, still solid. Whatever is upstairs comes out at night. Whatever is downstairs hasn't come out in a long time.

A session-sized adventure site. See The Iron Tower dungeon (page 53) for full details.

→ Fog Hollow (Hex 04) north, Tanglewood (Hex 13) south. Vision in Hex 04 points here. Job board mentions lights.

Hex 08: Miller's Fork (forest) *industrious*

Logging camp where two creeks meet. Six workers, a foreman named Dask (barrel-chested, impatient, shouts over the sound of axes), and a lot of fresh-cut timber. Dask is hiring guards: wolves have been bolder this season, circling the camp at night. He thinks it's a normal bad year. The wolves are actually being pushed out of the southern forest by a larger predator moving through their territory.

→ Thornwall (Hex 01) north, south road (Hex 12) south. Workers have seen traffic on the south road.

Hex 09: West Fields (farmland) *pastoral*

Patchwork of small farms and grazing land west of Thornwall. The Kettner family (biggest farmstead) supplies grain to the Antler & Axe. Old man Kettner (weathered, suspicious, sits on his porch with a crossbow) has seen "lights moving on the ridge at night, in a line, like a procession." He's not wrong: Cult members use the western ridge as a route to avoid Warden patrols.

→ Thornwall (Hex 01) east, western hills (Hex 11) south. Kettner's sighting points to Hex 11.

Hex 10: North Trail (hills) *windswept*

Rolling hills north of Thornwall. The trail here is old and well-maintained: flagstones visible under thin soil. This was a major road once. A Warden trail marker points north with the notation "Ashford, 4 days." Ashford is the nearest real town, outside the map. Merchant caravans come from this direction.

Good foraging. Rabbits, wild onion, clean streams. The safest hex on the map.

→ *Thornwall (Hex 01) south, Rocky Ridge (Hex 05) east. Trail leads off-map north (Ashford).*

A lightly keyed hex: terrain, mood, one detail, connections. Not every hex needs a quest. Some just need to feel real.



THE FRONTIER

Hexes 11-22. Ruins, contested territory, faction tensions. Sessions 4-7.

Hex 11: Western Ridge (hills) *lonely*

Bare ridge running north-south. Wind cuts across it constantly. A faint trail along the ridgeline shows recent foot traffic: the Bone Cult's supply route, bypassing Warden patrols. A stone marker halfway along the ridge holds a cache: dried meat, a waterskin, and a scrap of cloth with a symbol matching the marks in Hex 20.

→ *West Fields (Hex 09) north, contested forest (Hex 13) east, deep approach (Hex 23) south. Cult route runs through here.*

> **The Frontier is contested ground:** Warden markers on one side, Cult symbols on the other. Faction pressure in a hexcrawl works best when it's visible on the landscape, not just in NPC dialogue.

Hex 12: South Road (forest road) *uneasy*

The main road south from Thornwall. Once well-traveled, now overgrown in stretches. A merchant wagon (Collier's) sits overturned at a bend in the road, one wheel broken. Goods scattered: cloth, salt, iron nails. No blood, no body. Tracks lead off the road to the southwest. Collier is alive, held by bandits in Hex 19.

Fifty paces off the road, half-hidden by undergrowth: a skull the size of a horse cart, resting on the forest floor. The jaw has settled into moss. The eye sockets are large enough to crouch inside, and something has nested in one of them. Grey bone, not stone. The canopy has grown around it. Whatever this was died before the forest existed. No other bones in sight. Just the skull, watching the road.

→ *Miller's Fork (Hex 08) north, Warden Outpost (Hex 16) south. Tracks lead to Hex 19. Rumor 6 points here.*

> **Encounter Design Guidebook, Signs:** The overturned wagon is a sign, not an encounter. It tells the party something happened here and gives them tracks to follow. The encounter waits in Hex 19 when they choose to pursue it.

Hex 13: Tanglewood (dense forest) *claustrophobic*

Old-growth forest so dense that navigation is difficult. Canopy blocks most daylight. Movement still takes two watches per hex, but the penalty is orientation, not speed: trails look identical, landmarks disappear into the undergrowth, and navigation checks are harder than anywhere else in the Frontier. A stream runs through the middle, drinkable but stained dark brown by the trees. Deep game trails suggest large animals pass through at night.

Hidden in the undergrowth: a stone marker, hip-height, with Warden symbols on one side and Cult symbols scratched on the other. The Cult is overwriting Warden territory markers.

→ *Western Ridge (Hex 11) west, Winding River (Hex 03) north, Hex 15 south. Contested ground between factions.*

Hex 14: Old Road (forest) *overgrown*

Remnants of a paved road, now broken by roots and weather. The road ran east-west and is older than Thornwall. Following it east leads to the river (Hex 03), west to hills (Hex 11). Heavy tracks cross the road heading south: bipedal, widely spaced, pressing deep into the mud. A Warden trail blaze on a tree, three months old, reads: "large biped, southbound, nocturnal. Do not engage alone."

Where the road cuts through a low ridge, the exposed rock face reveals a cross-section of something embedded in the stone: an enormous blade, iron-black and straight-edged, running vertically through 20 feet of sedimentary rock. Not a natural formation. A weapon taller than a house, buried so long ago that the hill grew over it. The exposed edge is still sharp enough to cut leather.

→ *Winding River (Hex 03) north, Old Road continues in both directions. Tracks lead south toward Hex 18. Job board entry 2 points here.*

Hex 15: Coin Marsh (swamp) *treacherous*

Shallow marsh fed by the river's overflow. Named for the old coins that occasionally surface in the mud: silver, corroded dark, stamped with faces no scholar in Thornwall recognizes. Collecting a handful is easy. The coins are from a buried structure beneath the marsh, connected to the same civilization that built the tunnels in Hex 25.

Footing is terrible. Mist rises at dusk. Something large occasionally surfaces and submerges in the deeper pools, never fully seen.

→ *Tanglewood (Hex 13) north, deep swamp (Hex 24) south. Coins connect thematically to Hex 25 and Hex 28.*

If the party searches thoroughly (d4)

#	Discovery
1	Digging deeper where the coins surface, a flat stone slab appears at arm's depth. Carved with the same symbol system found in Hex 25. Too heavy to lift without tools or several strong backs.
2	Among the corroded coins, one is different: bright and uncorroded, stamped with a sharp clean face when the others are worn smooth. The face matches a carving in Hex 28. The Cult would want this badly.
3	A leather satchel, half-buried in the mud, holds a Warden's field journal. The last entry describes "structures visible beneath the water at low tide" and a hand-drawn map placing them directly under the deepest pool. The journal is from 40 years ago.
4	The large shape in the deeper pools surfaces close enough to identify: a turtle the size of a wagon wheel, its shell crusted with coins and mud. Not aggressive, but territorial. Its nest, visible at the pool's edge, sits on top of a stone lintel protruding from the ground.

Hex 16: Warden Outpost 3 (forest clearing) *abandoned*

A log cabin in a cleared area, built for two rangers. Supplies stocked, firewood stacked, gear packed neatly beside the bunks. No signs of struggle. The patrol log sits open on the table. Last entry, dated six days ago: "Heard digging southwest. Investigating at dawn. Back by nightfall." They didn't come back.

A trail leads southwest through dense forest toward Hex 21. Boot prints, two sets, heading out. No prints coming back.

→ *South Road (Hex 12) north, Hex 21 southwest. The Silent Outpost quest hook starts here.*

> The patrol log points to Hex 21, the quest drives exploration deeper. Every hex should leave a thread pointing outward.

Hex 17: Copper Gulch (ravine) *industrial*

A branch of the canyon system that includes Hex 06. Narrower, deeper. A mining crew (3) is camped at the entrance, working the walls with picks. They've been here a week and are nervous: strange sounds at night, tools going missing, the feeling of being watched. They haven't found the source.

Deeper in the gulch, the rock walls show the same smooth-melted quality as the tunnel in Hex 06. The copper vein runs through here too, but extraction is harder. Something has been moving the crew's tools to a pile near the deepest point of the gulch, as if trying to show them where to dig.

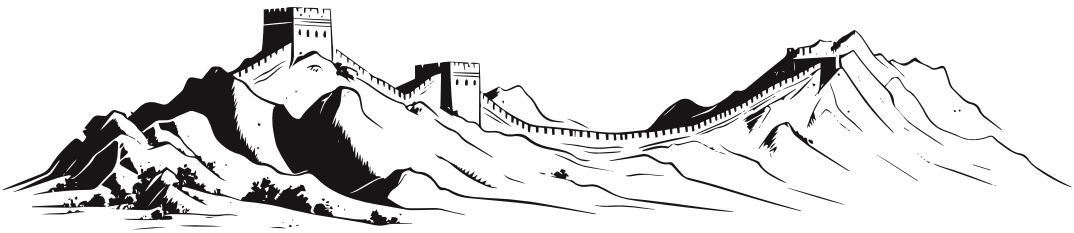
→ *Bone Pit (Hex 06) north, Hex 25 south (deep). Harsk's bounty connects to Hex 06. Miners will talk about the strangeness if asked.*

Hex 18: The Sentry (hilltop ruin) *imposing*

A hilltop with the foundation of a massive structure: walls 4 feet thick, cut from stone not found in this region. Only the ground floor remains, open to the sky. A stairway descends into a flooded lower level. The glint visible from Rocky Ridge (Hex 05) is a polished metal bracket set into the highest remaining wall, purpose unknown.

At night, the stone floor is warm underfoot. Not from the sun: it's hotter at midnight than at noon.

→ *Old Road (Hex 14) north, Hex 22 east, Hex 21 south. Visible from Hex 05. Heat from below connects to the Below.*



Hex 19: Bandit Camp (forest hollow) *desperate*

Four deserters from a southern militia, camped in a rocky hollow. They grabbed Collier and his goods because they're starving, not because they're organized. Their leader, a woman named Vekka (lean, scarred jaw, speaks like someone used to giving orders), will negotiate: return Collier and the goods in exchange for safe passage to Ashford and no Warden involvement.

Collier is unharmed but terrified. His wagon's cargo includes a nailed-shut crate he was told not to open. Inside: Warden supplies (the job board entry about stolen Warden supplies), being delivered to a drop point for the Bone Cult. Collier didn't know what he was carrying.

→ *Tracks from Hex 12, Cult supply route to Hex 20. The crate connects the job board entry about stolen Warden supplies, Rumor 6, and the Cult's logistics.*

Hex 20: Cult Waystation (forest) *secretive*

A clearing that looks natural but isn't. Trees have been thinned to create sight lines. A cache buried under a flat stone: food, tools, and a cloth map showing a route from Thornwall to the Deep, with Warden patrol schedules annotated in cipher. Cult symbols mark the trees at cardinal points.

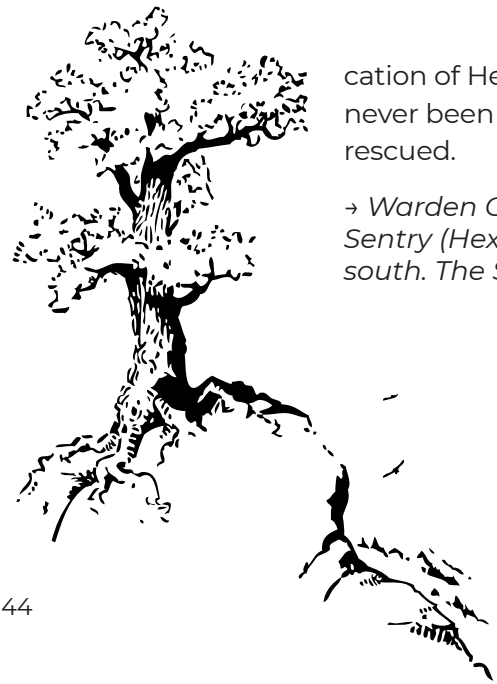
If the party stakes out the clearing, a Cult runner arrives within 1d3 days to collect supplies. The runner knows the route to Hex 28 but will not reveal it willingly.

→ Bandit Camp (Hex 19) north, Western Ridge (Hex 11) west, deep approach (Hex 24) south. Rumor 9 points here.

Hex 21: Warden's End (forest) *grim*

The two missing Warden rangers are here. One is dead: killed by a pit trap (sharpened stakes, recently constructed). The other, Ranger Kellis, is alive but injured, hiding in dense brush with a broken leg. She was investigating digging sounds when they walked into the trap.

Kellis can identify the trap as Bone Cult construction. She knows the location of Hex 28 from old patrol maps but has never been there. She'll share the location if rescued.



→ Warden Outpost (Hex 16) northeast, The Sentry (Hex 18) north, deep forest (Hex 24) south. The Silent Outpost quest leads here.

Hex 22: Tablet Ruin (hilltop ruin) *reverent*

A circular stone platform, cracked and tilted, on a bare hilltop. Four pillars remain of what were once many. At the center, a stone pedestal holds a carved tablet the size of a dinner plate, covered in symbols that match the carvings in Hexes 25 and 28.

The tablet lifts free easily. It's surprisingly heavy for its size, and is faintly warm. Brother Ashwick wants this (the Sexton's Offer quest). The symbols, if decoded, describe a locking mechanism: the tablet is a key to the locked chamber in Hex 28.

From the hilltop: a view south into the Deep. The forest canopy is darker there. On still nights, a faint vibration comes up through the stone underfoot.

→ *The Sentry (Hex 18) west, Deep (Hex 26) south. The Sexton's Offer quest hook points here. Tablet connects to Hex 28.*



This hex has connections in every direction: forward (quest), backward (Ashwick in town), and lateral (symbols match other hexes). See the Guidebook's Key Your Starting Region section.

THE DEEP

Hexes 23-30. Old magic, inhuman architecture, environmental hazards. Sessions 8-10+.

> The three-zone structure does something players feel before they understand it: keying density drops as danger rises. The Settled Ring has 10 hexes of dense prep. The Deep has 8 hexes with more space between keys. Less certainty, more room for something to surprise you.

Hex 23: Compass Break (forest) *unsettling*

The first sign that the rules are changing. Compass needles swing toward the excavation site. Navigation by instrument becomes unreliable. The forest here is old-growth, dark, with trees so large three people can't link arms around the trunks. Sound carries strangely: footsteps echo off nothing visible.

Navigation checks in the Deep are harder from this point on. Players who rely on compass bearings will get lost unless they adapt.

At the treeline where the old-growth begins, a Warden boundary marker stands at shoulder height: iron post, stamped with the Warden sigil and the single word "RECORDED." Below it, a Cult waymarker has been scratched into the bark of the nearest tree, pointing deeper. The two factions have both marked this threshold. Neither controls it.

Half-buried in loam and fern at the treeline: a fallen column of white stone, 50 feet long. Not from any quarry in the region. Carved with a spiral pattern that matches nothing in the Cult's symbol system or the Warden records. It lies pointing toward Hex 28, and it has been here longer than the forest.

Buried under the roots of the largest tree, a lodestone the size of a fist: naturally magnetic, hotter than stone should be at noon, and strong enough to recalibrate a compass if prepared correctly. Harsk would trade a week's supplies for it, and Sera Lindt would pay more.

→ Western Ridge (Hex 11) north, deep forest (Hex 26) east, Hex 24 south. Rumor 10 points here. First warning of the Below's influence.

Hex 24: Black Marsh (swamp) *oppressive*

> **Environmental escalation:** each hex in the Deep adds a new sensory layer of the Below's influence. By Hex 28, players should feel like they've been warned a dozen times. They have.

Deep swamp, waist-high water in places, with a smell of sulfur and rotting vegetation. The water is heated from below. Steam rises at dawn, creating visibility of 20 feet or less until midmorning.

Movement takes three watches per hex. Rations spoil faster here (lose one extra per day). At night, something displaces enough water to create waves across the marsh. Tracks on the rare dry patches show webbed feet the size of shields.

When the morning steam clears: the crown of a dome, smooth black stone, breaking the water's surface in the deepest pool. At least 60 feet across. Warm to the touch. The same material as the tunnels in Hex 25. The marsh grew over it. Whatever built the tunnels built structures on the surface too, and this one is still intact under the water. Anyone who touches the dome with bare hands feels a pulse of warmth and sees a brief flash: a map of tunnels branching outward from a central chamber, deeper than anything in Hex 25. The vision fades in seconds, but the layout stays in memory. A character who experienced this recognizes the tunnel junctions in Hex 25 on sight, cutting exploration time in half.

On one of the few dry islands, a Warden supply cache from a patrol that never returned: sealed rations, a waterproofed map of the Deep with three hexes marked that the current Wardens don't know about, and a bone-handled knife worth real money in Thornwall. The cache is why you came. The creature is why you'll move quickly.

→ Coin Marsh (Hex 15) north, Warden's End (Hex 21) northeast, Cult Excavation (Hex 28) south. Heated water connects to the Below.

Hex 25: The Smooth Tunnels (underground) *alien*

Accessible from Hex 06 (Bone Pit tunnel) or Hex 17 (Copper Gulch). The tunnels are not natural: walls are smooth as glass, curved, and they radiate heat. No tool marks. Whatever made them melted through solid rock. The tunnels branch and reconnect in patterns that don't follow mining logic.

Carvings appear deeper in: the same symbols found on the tablet (Hex 22), the coins (Hex 15), and the Cult waymarkers. The temperature rises the deeper you go. At the deepest accessible point, a sealed door of the same smooth stone. It has no handle, no keyhole. The tablet from Hex 22 fits a depression in the door's surface.

→ *Bone Pit (Hex 06) above, Copper Gulch (Hex 17) above. Sealed door connects to Hex 28. Carvings connect to Hexes 15, 22.*

Hex 26: Silent Forest (old-growth forest) *hushed*

The birds stopped singing here three weeks ago. The forest is alive but silent: trees still grow, insects still crawl, but no bird calls, no animal sounds, no wind noise despite the canopy moving overhead. Something has silenced this place from the inside out.

Deer stand motionless in clearings, eyes open, breathing slowly, all facing the same direction: toward Hex 28. They don't react to the party. They're not dead, not enchanted. They're listening to something the party can't hear yet.

Wedged into a hollow oak, wrapped in oilcloth: a Cult runner's satchel containing a complete cipher key for the annotations in Hex 20, three days of rations, and a charcoal sketch of the locked chamber door in Hex 28.

→ *Compass Break (Hex 23) west, Tablet Ruin (Hex 22) north, Hex 27 south. Rumor 12 points here. The silence gets worse closer to Hex 28.*

If the party searches thoroughly (d4)

#	Discovery
1	High in the canopy, a platform built from lashed branches. Climbing up reveals a Cult observation post: a charcoal tally of Warden patrols, a water flask, and a clear sight-line south toward Hex 28. The tally stopped eight days ago.
2	A ring of dead trees, bark stripped white, surrounding a patch of ground where nothing grows. The soil is warm to the touch. Placing an ear to the ground, you hear the same rhythmic pulse as Hex 27, faint but unmistakable.
3	One of the motionless deer has a leather cord around its neck with a carved bone token. The carving matches no known faction. If removed, the deer walks slowly south and does not stop.
4	A spring-fed pool, perfectly still. The water is drinkable and restorative: anyone who drinks and rests here for a watch recovers as if they'd had a full night's sleep. At the bottom, visible through the clear water, a stone face looks upward. Not carved from the rock beneath the pool. Placed there. A safe campsite if the silence doesn't drive you out first.

Hex 27: The Breathing Hills (hills) *dread*

Low, rounded hills with sparse vegetation. The ground here vibrates: a rhythmic pulse, roughly every six seconds, felt through boot soles and in the chest. Like a heartbeat. Loose stones rattle. Water in containers ripples. The pulse is strongest at night.

An old Warden camp, long abandoned: collapsed tent poles, a firepit, and a stone marker reading "HERE AND NO FURTHER. By order of Warden-Captain Aldric, year 27." The year dating is from a calendar nobody in Thornwall uses anymore.

→ *Silent Forest (Hex 26) north, Cult Excavation (Hex 28) east. The vibration points to Hex 28. Old Warden marker confirms the Wardens have been drawing this line for generations.*

Hex 28: The Excavation (ruin/underground) *terrible*

The Bone Cult's base of operations. A cleared area around a massive stone structure half-buried in the hillside. Tents, tools, a cooking fire, guard posts. 8-12 Cult members (dangerous as a group, moderate individually). The Sexton works inside the structure and emerges only at night, masked.

Inside: a descending corridor of the same polished stone as the tunnels in Hex 25, wider and more ornate. It leads to a sealed chamber. If the tablet from Hex 22 has been delivered, the chamber is open and the air itself has changed: the vibration is stronger, the air is uncomfortably hot, and the Cult members are behaving strangely (ecstatic, fearful, or both).

What's in the chamber is left open. The module provides the approach, the clues, and the factions. The answer is yours.

If you want a starting point, roll a d4 or just pick one:

D4	The chamber holds
1	A sleeping entity, vast and old, not evil but not safe. The Cult's "transformation" is real. The Wardens' fear is also real.
2	A geological anomaly: a node where the earth's heat vents in a focused beam. The effects are natural, the symbols are ancient human attempts to understand them.
3	A trapped intelligence, not a creature but a recorded mind from a dead civilization, waiting to communicate with anyone who opens the door.
4	A transformation engine: a device that reshapes living things over time. The Cult members are already changing. So are the animals.

These are prompts, not canon. Use one as a seed, discard the rest, or mix two together. See the Bone Cult Excavation dungeon for full details (page 56).

→ Breathing Hills (Hex 27) west, Smooth Tunnels (Hex 25) via underground, Black Marsh (Hex 24) north. Everything points here.

Hex 29: The Scar (ravine) *desolate*

A deep gash in the landscape, running east-west. The walls expose layers of rock in wrong colors: blue stone over red over black. At the bottom, a dry streambed with fragments of worked stone, as if a building collapsed into the ravine from above. The fragments carry the warmth of something alive beneath the surface, despite the open air.

Climbing down is possible but risky. At the bottom, a carved archway leads into the hillside. Beyond: darkness, air that shimmers with heat, and a sound like breathing.

What makes this approach different from Hex 28: no Cult presence, no excavation equipment, no signs of recent use. The archway's carvings are in a second symbol system, distinct from the ones at Hex 25 and Hex 28, as if a different group, or a different era, attempted entry here. Someone reached this point before the Cult did, and didn't stay.

→ *The Excavation (Hex 28) north, Hex 30 east. Another approach to the Below.*

If the party searches thoroughly (d4)

#	Discovery
1	Among the worked stone fragments, a piece of a mosaic floor: colored tiles forming part of a face. The craftsmanship is finer than anything at Hex 25 or Hex 28. Whoever built here had more skill, or more time.
2	Scratched into the archway's inner wall, in Common, in a shaking hand: "It opened for me. I closed it again. Do not bring fire." No signature. The scratches are decades old.
3	A stone fragment with a hinge mechanism still attached. The metal is warm, like the rest of the worked stone, but this piece moves. Pressing the hinge causes a click, and a section of wall six paces deeper into the archway shifts inward by a finger's width. Not enough to pass through. Not yet.
4	At the base of the ravine wall, a cairn of stacked stones. Beneath the top stone, a sealed tin box. Inside: a short sword of unfamiliar metal, black-bladed, lighter than steel and warm to the grip. It holds an edge without sharpening. Wrapped around the blade, a cloth map of the tunnel system below, more complete than anything the Wardens or Cult possess. The sword is worth 500 silver to the right buyer. The map is worth more to Harsk or Voss.

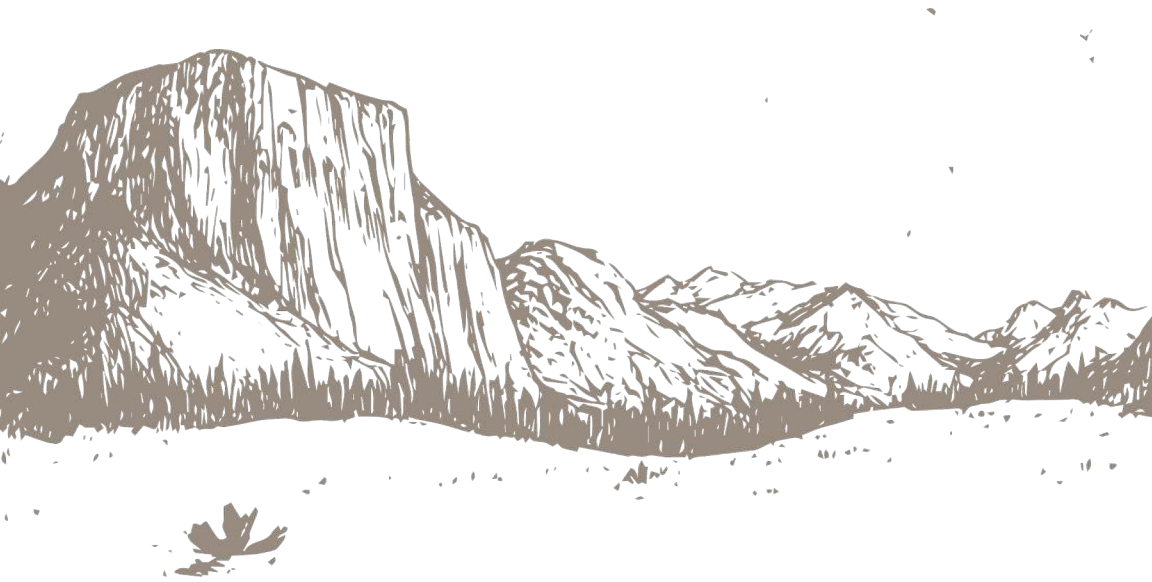
Hex 30: World's Edge (cliffs) *vast*

The frontier ends at a cliff face dropping 200 feet to a densely forested valley below. The view is staggering: an unbroken canopy stretching to the horizon, with no sign of habitation. Somewhere in that valley, a column of heat shimmers above the canopy, visible only at dawn.

A Warden marker, centuries old, is carved into the cliff face: "Beyond this point, the maps end." Below the official marker, someone has scratched a Bone Cult symbol and a date from this year.

This is the edge of the module. What's below the cliff and beyond the valley is expansion territory or a sequel.

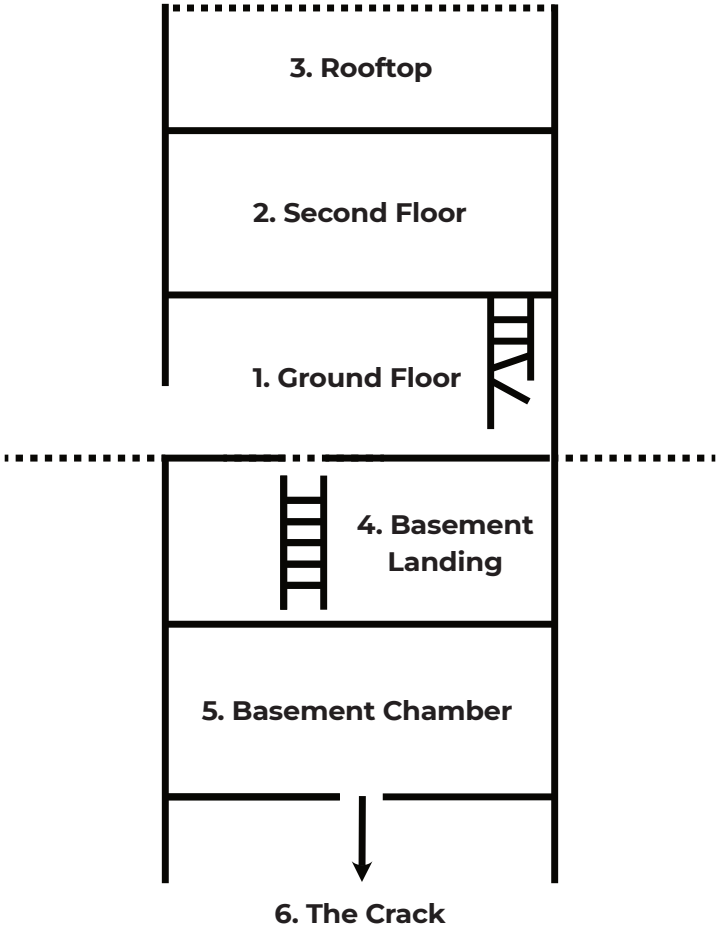
→ The Scar (Hex 29) west. Expansion zone south. The cliff marks the boundary between known and unknown.



The Iron Tower

One entrance, multiple paths, a central mystery. A session-sized site works because it can be started and finished in one sitting.

Dungeon: Hex 07



Overview: Three-story stone tower, partially collapsed. Something lives on the upper floors. Something else is locked in the basement. The Wardens locked this place a generation ago. The seal is weakening.

Threat level: Moderate. A cautious party of 3-4 can handle this. Reckless parties will get hurt.

1. Ground Floor

Open doorway (no door). Cold fire pit, claw marks on walls, animal bones. Stairs up (partially collapsed, climbable). Iron door down (locked, heavy). A Warden seal on the iron door, cracked but intact: a warning sigil meaning "contained threat." Fresh claw marks suggest the beast upstairs has been testing the door.

2. Second Floor

Reached by climbing collapsed stairs. A nest of dried branches, fur, and torn cloth. Occupant: a territorial beast (use whatever large predator fits your system: owlbear, cave bear, dire wolf). It hunts at night and sleeps here during the day. Treasure: a miner's tool belt caught in the nest, containing a map fragment showing Hex 17.

3. Rooftop

Open to the sky. Good vantage point: visible are Hexes 04, 13, 18, and on clear nights, a faint glow from the south (Hex 28). A broken mechanism: gears, a metal frame, the remains of a signal device. This tower was part of a network. The other towers are gone.

4. Basement Landing

Behind the iron door. Steep stairs descending 20 feet. Heat rises from below. A faint hum, felt in the teeth. The Warden seal's magic is what keeps the door locked. The physical lock broke years ago.

Shelves along the stairway hold old Warden supplies: two sealed ration packs (still good), a coil of rope, and a logbook describing what was locked down here.

5. Basement Chamber

A circular room with walls of the same melted stone as Hex 25. An iron cage in the center holds... nothing visible. But the cage door is bent outward and the cage is uncomfortably warm despite no fire. Whatever was contained here may have escaped through a crack in the floor that leads deeper. Or it may still be here, invisible, waiting. Decide before the party investigates.

The cage itself is made of rare metal, worth a significant sum if broken down and hauled out. The melted-stone walls contain copper traces richer than anything in Hex 06.

6. The Crack

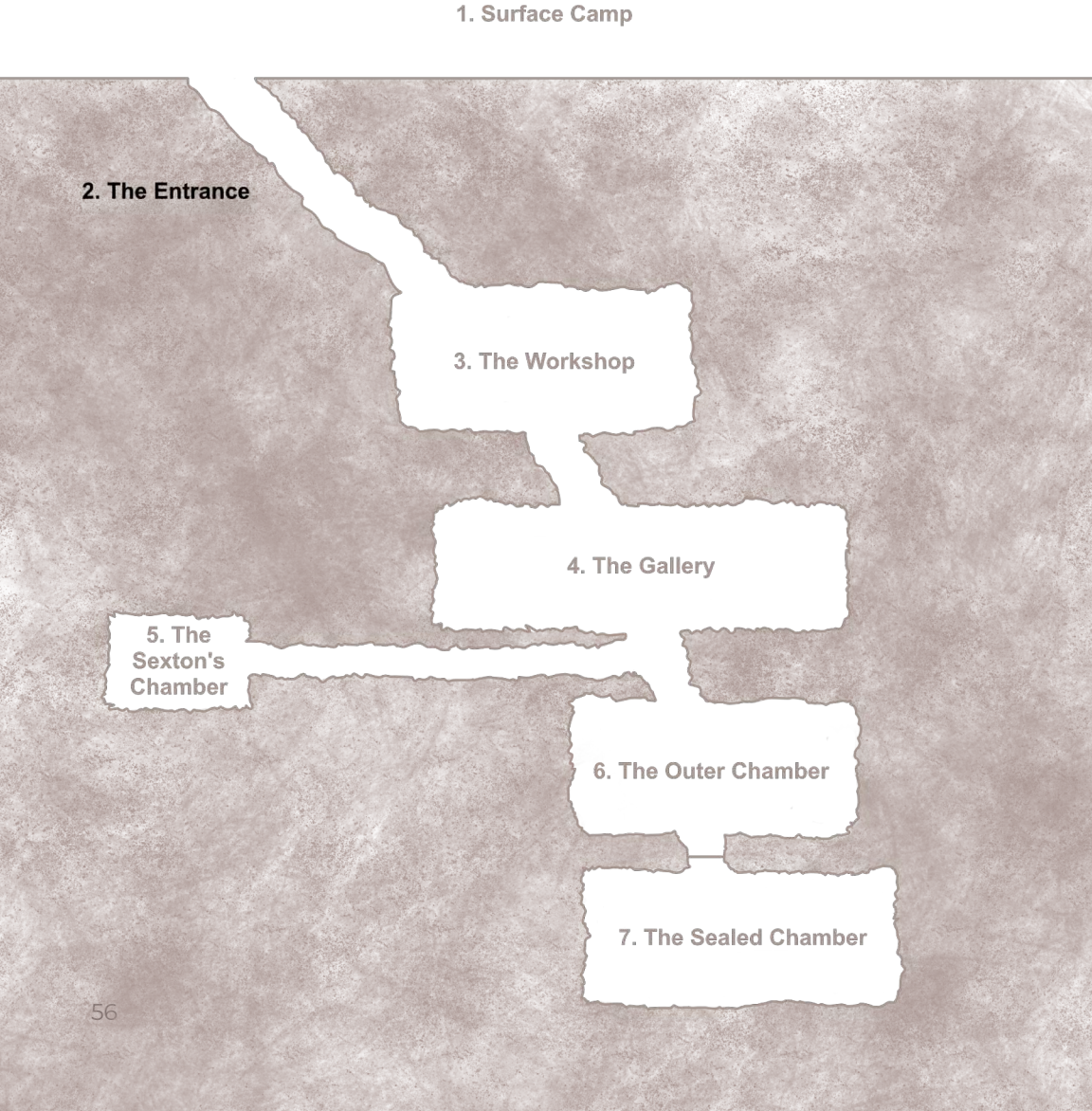
A narrow fissure in the basement floor, barely wide enough to squeeze through. Heat pulses from below. It connects, eventually, to the tunnel system in Hex 25. A shortcut to the Deep for parties brave or foolish enough to use it.

Secret: The signal mechanism on the roof, if repaired (difficult, requires specific parts from Hex 18), can send a pulse of light visible for miles. The Wardens used it to coordinate patrols. Reactivating it draws the attention of both the Wardens (positive) and the Cult (negative).

The Bone Cult Excavation

Dungeon: Hex 28

The Bone Cult's excavation: surface camp and underground chambers.



Overview: The Bone Cult's primary site. A half-buried structure of pre-human construction, now partially excavated. The Sexton directs operations from inside. A sealed chamber at the lowest level is the Cult's objective.

Threat level: Dangerous. The Cult fights to protect this site. Stealth, negotiation, or overwhelming force are all viable approaches.

If the party wants to join the Cult, the Sexton is willing to negotiate. He needs muscle and fresh supplies. Working with the Cult gives the party access to the excavation but puts them on the wrong side of the Wardens. Voss will treat them as hostile if she finds out.

1. Surface Camp

Tents, supplies, a cooking fire, two guards at the entrance. The guards are alert but not paranoid: they expect supply runners, not attackers. A supply manifest lists stolen Warden gear, rations for 12, and "the instrument" (the tablet from Hex 22, if delivered).

2. Entry Corridor

Cut stone, polished to a sheen, descending at a 15-degree angle. Lit by oil lamps hung on iron brackets. Cult symbols painted on the walls in reddish paint. The stone is warm underfoot. 60 feet to room 3.

3. The Workshop

Tools, notebooks, fragments of carved stone arranged on tables. A Cult scholar is usually here, cataloguing finds. The notebooks contain translations of the wall carvings: fragmented references to "the Sleeper," "the gift of transformation," and "the price." The translations are incomplete and possibly wrong.

4. The Gallery

A long, high-ceilinged chamber with carved walls depicting figures descending into the earth. The figures change as you walk deeper: human at the entrance, less human at the far end. The floor has a mosaic showing the region's geography as it was centuries ago. Some features match the current landscape. Some don't.

5. The Sexton's Chamber

Private quarters carved from the corridor wall. A cot, a desk, and a locked chest. The chest contains: the Sexton's journal (documenting two years of excavation), a complete translation key for the wall symbols, and a wax-stopped letter addressed to "my successor." The Sexton is here 50% of the time, always masked.

Secret: The Sexton's journal reveals that two previous excavation attempts (decades and centuries apart) reached this point and stopped. Both times, the excavators collapsed the corridor behind them and left. The Sexton doesn't know why. The journal's tone shifts from confident to uncertain in the final entries.

6. The Outer Chamber

The last room before the sealed chamber. The air is uncomfortably hot. The vibration from Hex 27 is strong enough to make speech difficult. Carved above the doorway: a single symbol that the translation key renders as "WAKE" or possibly "OPEN" or possibly "FEED." The Cult chose to believe the first meaning.

7. The Sealed Chamber

A door of smooth stone with a tablet-shaped depression. If the tablet is placed, the door opens. What's inside is yours to decide. The module gives you: warm air, a low sound, the smell of copper, and a darkness that lantern light doesn't fully penetrate. The Cult expected a god. The Wardens expected a weapon. The clues suggest something older and stranger than either label fits.

Weather and seasons

Weather (d6 each day)

#	Spring	Summer	Autumn	Winter
1	Clear, mild	Hot, still	Crisp, clear	Cold, clear
2	Overcast, warm	Hazy, humid	Overcast, cool	Grey, bitter cold
3	Light rain	Thunderstorms	Drizzle, fog	Light snow
4	Heavy rain	Hot, dry wind	Heavy rain, mud	Heavy snow
5	Fog (morning)	Clear, perfect	Wind and rain	Blizzard
6	Sudden cold	Violent storm	First frost	Thaw (brief)

Seasonal effects by terrain

#	Spring	Summer	Autumn	Winter
Forest	Muddy trails, flooding streams	Dense foliage blocks sight lines	Falling leaves, clear sight	Snow reveals tracks
Hills	Wildflowers, good foraging	Dry, fire risk	Wind exposure	Ice on slopes, avalanche risk
Swamp	Water rises, paths submerge	Insects intolerable	Water recedes, new paths	Partial freeze, treacherous
Ruins	Flooding in lower levels	Nesting creatures active	Structural weakening	Ice makes climbing dangerous
River	Spring flood, impassable	Low water, easy crossing	Normal flow	Frozen (check thickness)

Mechanical Effects (system-agnostic)

Rain/Snow: Ranged attacks harder. Tracks wash away. Fire-starting takes longer. Visibility reduced.

Fog: Visibility 30-60 feet. Navigation harder. Ambush easier. Sound travels unpredictably.

Extreme cold: Lose 1 extra ration per day (fuel for fires). Exposed water freezes. Metal is painful to touch bare-handed.

Extreme heat: Lose 1 extra water ration per day. Heavy armor is punishing. Rest in shade or suffer.

Wind: Ranged attacks harder. Conversation difficult. Climbing exposed surfaces is dangerous.

Mud: Movement speed reduced by half in affected terrain. Carts and wagons get stuck.

Weather and encounters. Weather modifies encounter rolls, not encounter tables. In fog, anything that relies on sight (vantage points, distant smoke, trail markers) is invisible. In heavy rain or snow, tracks wash away and navigation checks get harder. Storms force camp or shelter decisions that override travel plans. When you roll a weather result that conflicts with an encounter roll, let the weather win: a thunderstorm turns *"clear views from the ridge"* into *"hunker down and hope the lightning misses."* The encounter is still there when the weather clears.

NPC Roster

Quick Reference

Name	Location	Disposition	Summary
Harsk Deepwell	Thornwall	Friendly	Miners' Guild leader. Hires the party. Pragmatic, direct.
Captain Elara Voss	Thornwall	Wary	Grey Warden commander. Four rangers left. Shares intel if trusted.
Marta Greaves	Thornwall	Neutral	Healer. Sharp-tongued. Keeps strange specimens.
Joss Kettleburn	Thornwall	Friendly	Innkeeper, Antler & Axe. Manages job board.
Sera Lindt	Thornwall	Nervous	Assayer. Notices strange minerals. Hasn't told anyone.
Old Tam	Thornwall	Friendly	Retired miner. Seen the excavation site before the Cult.
Wren	Thornwall	Friendly	Young Warden ranger. Talkative. Posted at the gate.
Brother Ashwick	Thornwall	Hidden	Bone Cult informant posing as priest.
Dask	Hex 08	Busy	Logging camp foreman. Hiring guards for wolf problem.
Old man Kettner	Hex 09	Grumpy	Farmer. Seen Cult processions on the western ridge.
Vekka	Hex 19	Desperate	Bandit leader. Will negotiate for safe passage.
Collier	Hex 19	Terrified	Merchant. Unknowing Cult supply mule.
Ranger Kellis	Hex 21	Injured	Warden. Knows Hex 28 location. Needs rescue.
The Sexton	Hex 28	Hostile	Bone Cult leader. Never unmasked. Drives excavation.
Mining crew (3)	Hex 17	Nervous	Workers in Copper Gulch. Spooked by strange events.

GM Reference Sheets

> Keep these pages open during play. It's the Guidebook's Exploration Turn Reference Card applied to this region.

Exploration Turn

(Per watch: one six-hour block. Morning, afternoon, evening, night.)

A. Direction: Party declares which hex they're heading toward. **B. Navigation:** Check if they stay on course. Harder in swamp, dense forest, fog, and the Deep (compass unreliable). Getting lost shifts them one hex in a random direction. **C. Movement:** One hex per watch on clear terrain. Two watches for rough terrain (forest, hills). Three watches for harsh terrain (swamp, mountains, Deep). **D. Encounters:** Roll 1d6. On a 1, roll on the terrain encounter table. In the Frontier, encounter on 1-2. In the Deep, encounter on 1-3. **E. Keyed content:** If they enter a keyed hex, describe what they find. **F. Resources:** Deduct 1 ration per person per day. Deduct extra in harsh conditions (see Weather).

Party roles: Mapper (tracks the map), Caller (announces direction each watch), Quartermaster (manages rations and gear), Chronicler (records events and discoveries).

> Campaign Playstyle Guidebook, Party Roles: Assigning these four roles at session 1 distributes the bookkeeping and gives every player a job beyond "my character." The mapper alone transforms how players engage with the hex map.

Encounter Frequency

Zone	Encounter on...	Table
Settled Ring (01-10)	1 on d6	Terrain-specific
Frontier (11-22)	1-2 on d6	Terrain-specific
The Deep (23-30)	1-3 on d6	Terrain-specific or Ruins

Some events add +1 to the next encounter check. This means you add 1 to the d6 result, widening the trigger range by one.

Encounter Design Guidebook, Frequency by Zone: The escalating trigger range (1, then 1-2, then 1-3) means Deep hexes produce roughly three times the encounters of Settled hexes. Players feel the danger increase through encounter density, not just through tougher opponents.

Terrain Movement Costs

Terrain	Watches per hex	Notes
Road/Trail	½	Fastest. Easier navigation.
Farmland/Plains	1	Open ground.
Forest	2	Dense forest: navigation harder.
Hills	2	Climbing. Good vantage points.
Swamp	3	Exhausting. Leeches. Gear damage.
Mountains	3	Dangerous. Weather exposure.
River crossing	+1 watch	River crossing, bridge, or boat needed.

Navigation Difficulty

Condition	Modifier
Road or trail	Automatic success
Clear terrain, good visibility	Easy
Forest or hills	Normal
Dense forest, swamp, or fog	Hard
The Deep (compass unreliable)	Very hard
Night travel without light	Hard

Foraging & Water

Terrain	Foraging	Water
Forest	Good. Berries, game, roots.	Streams common.
Hills	Moderate. Small game, herbs.	Springs at lower elevations.
Swamp	Poor. Edible plants but risky.	Abundant but often unsafe.
Farmland	Excellent near settlements.	Wells and streams.
Ruins	None.	Cisterns (check safety).
The Deep	Strange. Edible but unsettling.	Heated. Tastes of copper.

Rest & Camp

Short rest: One watch. Recover minor injuries. No travel.

Long rest: Full night (night watch). Recover fully. Requires fire, shelter, rations.

Watch rotation: Divide the night into shifts. A character on watch doesn't rest fully. Solo travelers can't keep watch and rest.

Camp quality: Sheltered (cave, building, dense tree cover) means better rest and fire safety. Exposed camps risk weather effects and are easier to find.

Threat Descriptors

Use these instead of stat blocks:

Descriptor	Meaning
Minor	Annoying, not dangerous. Insects, small animals, minor hazards.
Moderate	A cautious party can handle it. Expect some resource cost.
Dangerous	Real risk of injury or death. Retreat is a valid option.
Deadly	Will kill unprepared parties. Avoid or plan carefully.
Overwhelming	Run. Now. Come back with an army or a better plan.

Faction Attitudes at a Glance

Faction	Starts	Improves if…	Worsens if…
Miners' Guild	Friendly	Party brings finds, completes jobs	Party blocks mining, sides with Wardens against expansion
Wardens	Wary	Party proves careful, rescues rangers	Party disturbs sealed sites, works for the Cult
Bone Cult	Hidden	Party delivers tablet, ignores Cult	Party discovers Cult, helps Wardens

Key NPCs at a Glance

Name	Location	Role
Harsk Deepwell	Thornwall (Deepwell Outfitters)	Miners' Guild leader. Hires the party, buys finds.
Captain Elara Voss	Thornwall (Warden Station)	Grey Warden commander. Shares intel if trusted.
Marta Greaves	Thornwall (clinic)	Healer. Knows everyone's business and keeps strange specimens.
Joss Kettleburn	Thornwall (Antler & Axe)	Innkeeper. Manages the job board. Tracks who's out and who's overdue.
Brother Ashwick	Thornwall (chapel)	Bone Cult informant posing as priest. Gathering intelligence on the Deep.

Expansion Hex Sheets

Templates for New Hexes

Use these to add your own hexes when players push beyond the map or when you want to expand the region. Photocopy these pages.

Field	Your Notes
Hex #	
Name (terrain)	
Mood	
Description	
Keyed Content	
Connections	
Encounter Modifier	

Field	Your Notes
Hex #	
Name (terrain)	
Mood	
Description	
Keyed Content	
Connections	
Encounter Modifier	

Field	Your Notes
Hex #	
Name (terrain)	
Mood	
Description	
Keyed Content	
Connections	
Encounter Modifier	

Beyond the Map

The Thornwall Frontier is designed to end at its edges. When your players look past the borders, give them a reason to push further. Each direction offers a different kind of game.

North: Civilization

The road to Ashford connects Thornwall to the wider world. Ashford is a real town: markets, a garrison, a temple, politics. The party's discoveries on the frontier have value here: ore samples, maps, intelligence about the Cult. Ashford also has people who want things from the frontier. A merchant prince. A scholar obsessed with pre-human ruins. A Warden general who thought the frontier problem was solved a generation ago.

Going north means trading exploration for negotiation and the complications that come with civilization caring about what you've found.

East: Deeper Wilderness

The canyon system continues east, getting deeper and stranger. The river's source is somewhere in the mountains, and the tunnels in Hex 25 extend in that direction. More ruins. Larger creatures. Terrain that requires specialized gear (climbing equipment, boats). The Below's influence is strong here: compass anomalies, stone that radiates heat, the vibration.

Going east means harder exploration with bigger discoveries and greater danger.

South: The Below

Below the cliff in Hex 30 lies a valley that may be the surface expression of the Below itself. Whatever the party finds down there, heat, strange growth, stone that doesn't belong. These are all symptoms. The cause is underground, and it's older than human memory.

Going south means confronting the central mystery of the module head-on. The Sleeper is down there, and the valley is where its influence breaks the surface.

West: The Abandoned Frontier

People used to live west of Thornwall. They don't anymore. The ruins and place names out there are remnants of a previous attempt to settle this region. The settlers left for reasons no one in Thornwall remembers clearly. The Below's influence is one explanation. Bad luck is another.

Going west means uncovering history: why this frontier has been settled and abandoned before, and whether this cycle will repeat. I'd run the west as a slow-burn discovery. Let the players piece it together from ruins and names before anything confirms it.

Naming Your Hexes

The names in this module follow a pattern: plain descriptive English based on terrain, function, or local landmarks. Thornwall (the thorn hedges on the ridge), Miller's Fork (the logging camp at a creek junction), Bone Pit (fossils in the ravine), Coin Marsh (the coins in the mud). When you add hexes, use the same approach. Name the thing the first settler or prospector would have called it. Avoid grand or mythic names unless the place earned one through play. "Burnt Ridge" because a wildfire scarred it. "Voss's Cairn" because the party buried a ranger there. The best hex names come from what happened, not what you planned.

Final Note

This module gives you a region, three factions, and a mystery with a spine.

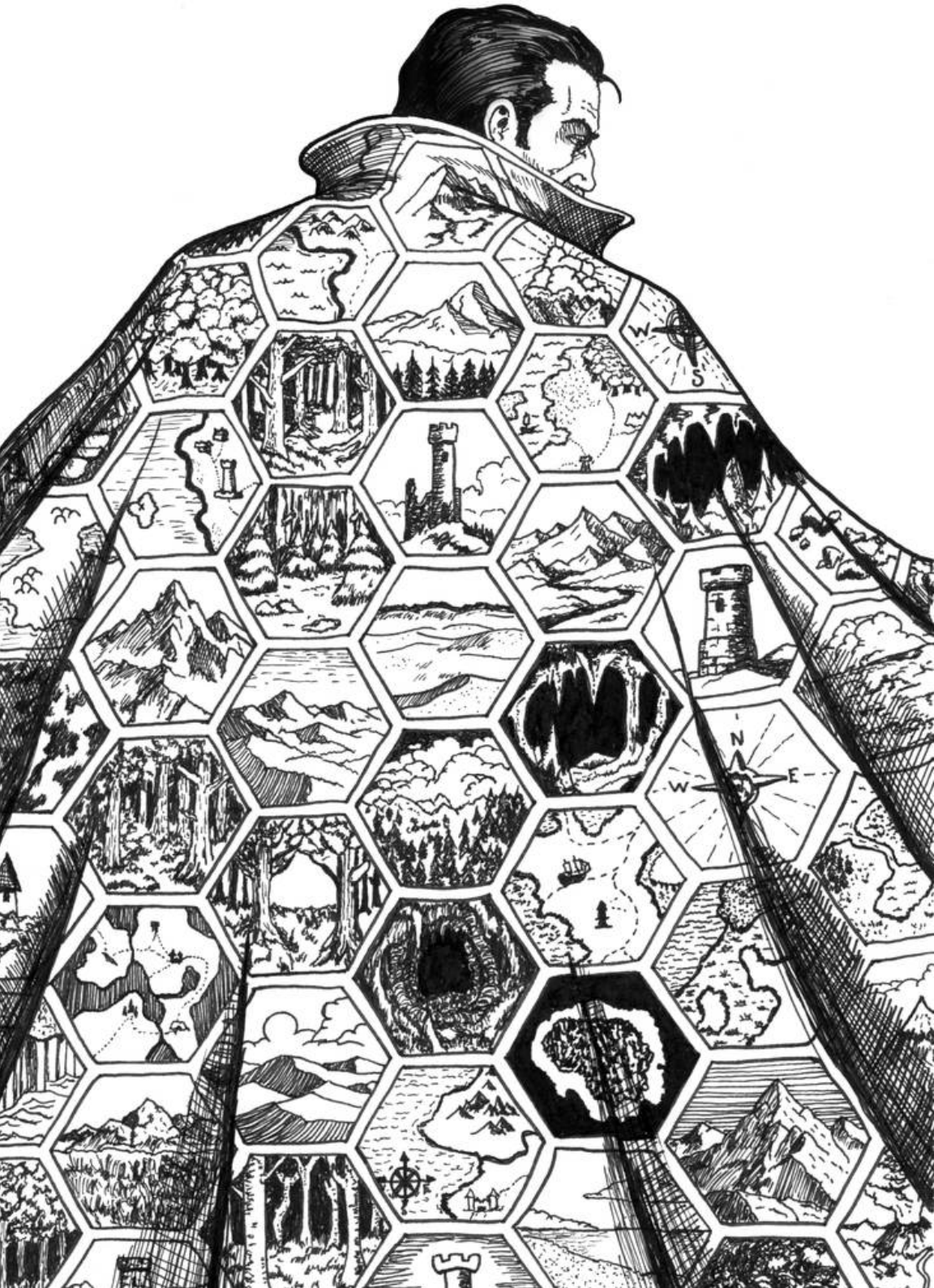
I recommend running the deep-below mystery as your story arc. Let the party follow the tunnels, the carvings, and the vibrations until they find what's underneath. That gives the campaign a destination. The faction conflicts and hex discoveries along the way give it texture.

But the arc is not the boundary. Encourage your players to explore every ridge, ruin, and marsh crossing. Follow rumors that lead nowhere obvious. Talk to NPCs who have nothing to do with the main thread. The Thornwall Frontier has more in it than any single story arc needs, and that is the point. There is no real limit to how long a group can spend here.

If the party sides with the Wardens, the frontier gets safer but the mystery stays buried. If they help the Miners, Thornwall grows rich but the digging continues. If the Cult succeeds, the frontier changes, and you'll know when it happens.

Run it again with a different group. Different players pick different hexes first, side with different factions, and miss different things. Compare notes with other GMs who have run the Thornwall Frontier. Where did their group go first? Did they find the tunnels early or late? How did they handle the Cult? Did anyone reach the Excavation before session five? Every table's version of this region is different, and that is worth talking about.

I designed this module to run itself once the party starts moving. Run it Friday. See what happens.


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PRESENTS

The Hexcrawl Series

The Frontier That Pulled Them In: *The party takes a mining job, heads east, and comes back with a copper sample and a question: why is the stone warm? Next session, a Warden patrol warns them off the ruins. Session after, symbols scratched into a canyon wall. Three sessions in, the map is full of questions and no one told them where to go.*

Prep in an evening. Run it on Friday. *A complete 30-hex starting region built around the frontier town of Thornwall. Three factions, keyed hexes across three zones, and a central mystery that unfolds through what the party finds, not what you narrate. 10–15 sessions.*

System-neutral. *No stat blocks. For GMs who want a region that plays, not just reads.*

THE SERIES

The Hexcrawl Guidebook *covers maps, exploration turns, and the procedures that hold a hexcrawl together. Start here if you're new.*

The Encounter Design Guidebook *is the next step when your random tables feel thin. It covers the four encounter categories, faction presence, slow threats, and pacing across a day of travel.*

The Worldbuilding Guidebook *walks you through building a region in one evening. Terrain, ruins, roads, and factions layered so every location connects.*